



CITY: PG 3

Private school's seven-day test



NATION: PG 5

Speaker Birla appeals to all parties for smooth conduct of Monsoon Session



FILM: PG 12

Rakul Preet Singh calls 'Ramayana' bigger than cinema

DELIMITATION, AYODHYA ROW AND PAPER LEAKS SET STAGE

Parl braces for stormy Monsoon session as Centre, Oppn gear up for showdown

VINAY KUMAR

NEW DELHI: The Monsoon session of Parliament is all set to begin from Monday on a stormy note as a number of issues such as Ram temple donation thefts in Ayodhya, exam paper leaks and the protest by activist Sonam Wangchuk, and ethanol blending with petrol will top the agenda of the Opposition to corner the BJP-led NDA government.

However, the complexion of the Opposition has undergone a change since Parliament's last session in April as 37 MPs from four Opposition parties have switched their allegiance to the ruling combine of NDA.

The government is keen on pressing ahead with its legislative business of several crucial bills, including the earlier-defeated Constitution

HIGHLIGHTS

» Opposition to raise Ayodhya Ram temple donation row and exam paper leaks

» Sonam Wangchuk's protest and ethanol blending also on Opposition's agenda

» Opposition weakened after 37 MPs from four parties joined the NDA

» Government to push



key bills, including women's reservation and delimitation proposal

» Congress seeks all-party discussion on delimitation and women's reservation

Amendment Bill on delimitation, though it is not yet listed in the legislative agenda.

High drama unfolded at the Centre's customary all-party meeting ahead of Monday's session of Parliament on Sunday as MPs from the INDIA

bloc walked out of the meeting amid a controversy over separate seating arrangements for rebel Trinamool Congress (TMC) MPs. The Opposition leaders, however, later rejoined the meeting, describing their walkout as a symbolic protest.

The meeting, convened by Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju at the Parliament Annexe, was attended by floor leaders of major political parties to discuss the government's legislative agenda and issues likely

INDIA bloc protests NCPI invite, stages symbolic walkout

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: INDIA bloc leaders staged a symbolic walkout from Sunday's all-party meeting in protest against the invitation extended to rebel MPs who left the Trinamool Congress and joined the Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI).

The walkout was led by TMC MPs, including Mahua Moitra and Saugata Roy, and joined by representatives

Delhi HC keeps Wangchuk at Safdarjung, supporters prepare for march to Parl

Wangchuk will end fast if Parliament session focuses on education accountability, says his wife Angmo



AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: As thousands of students, teachers, parents, job aspirants and professionals gathered at Jantar Mantar on Sunday ahead of the proposed "Chalo Parliament" march, activist Sonam Wangchuk's legal battle over his continued stay at Safdarjung Hospital unfolded simultaneously in the Delhi High Court. The court declined to interfere with his treatment at the government-run hospital or permit his immediate transfer to a private medical facility of his choice, even as supporters intensified preparations for Monday's march demanding education reforms and the

Section 163 in force as Delhi Police deny CJP march permission

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police on Sunday said no permission had been sought or granted for the Cockroach Janta Party's proposed "Chalo Sansad" march on Monday, ahead of the Monsoon session of Parliament. In a statement, police said they had received reports about the planned march to Parliament but clarified that no approval had been given for any protest march or procession. Police also said prohibitory orders under Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita are in force in New Delhi district.

resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

Court declines relief to Wangchuk

In a special Sunday hearing, Justice Mini Pushkarna refused to grant interim relief on a petition filed by Wangchuk's wife,

J&K WORST HIT

Monsoon lashes north and east, leaves at least 17 dead



Houses are seen damaged in the aftermath of torrential rain-triggered landslides and flash floods, in Rajouri district, Jammu and Kashmir, Sunday

Swear words, profanities, vulgar expletive alone do not amount to obscenity: SC

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has said that mere swear words, profanities and vulgar expletives, however offensive or uncivil, will not amount to obscenity.

A bench of Justices Sanjay Karol and Vipul M Pancholi -- while hearing a man's plea challenging a high court order that confirmed the trial court's conviction of him under Section 294 of the Indian Penal Code (IPC) -- observed that abusive or vulgar language by itself does not constitute the offence of obscenity under the Section.

"For an utterance to be considered obscene, it must be shown that it was lascivious, appealed to prurient interests and had the tendency to deprave and corrupt the minds of those who are exposed to it. "Tested on this anvil, even if all the allegations levelled in the complaint

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MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: At least 17 people lost their lives in rain-related incidents across northern and eastern India on Sunday, with Jammu and Kashmir accounting for 12 of the deaths as torrential rain triggered landslides and flash floods that damaged roads, houses and other infrastructure.

The situation was most severe in the twin border districts of Poonch and Rajouri, where heavy rain caused widespread destruction. Officials said Surankote tehsil in Poonch district suffered the worst damage, with most of the fatalities reported from the area. Rescue teams continued search operations to trace missing persons.

TAKEAWAYS

» J&K accounts for 12 deaths

» Amarnath Yatra suspended

» IMD predicts widespread rain

» Uttarakhand reports two lightning deaths

» Three killed in Nagaland's Mon district

A police official said another body was recovered in the Surankote area on Sunday evening, taking the death toll in Poonch to 10. Two more people, including a woman, died in flash floods in neighbouring Rajouri district, raising the overall toll in Jammu and Kashmir to 12.

The worsening situation prompted Chief Minister

Omar Abdullah to cancel his participation in the National Conference's proposed statehood protest in Delhi on Monday and instead travel to Jammu to oversee relief measures. Abdullah reached the Civil Secretariat around 6 pm and chaired a high-level meeting to review the situation and coordinate the response.

The heavy rainfall also disrupted the annual Amarnath Yatra. Authorities temporarily suspended the pilgrimage from both the Pahalgam and Baltal routes after the Meteorological Department forecast widespread rainfall across Jammu and Kashmir over the coming days.

Officials stopped the onward movement of pilgrims from the Baltal and

Continued on P4

PV Sindhu ends title drought

Wins maiden Japan Open title, first Indian to lift the prestigious tournament

MPOST BUREAU

TOKYO: Two-time Olympic medallist PV Sindhu returned to the winner's circle in style on Sunday, defeating home favourite and three-time world champion Akane Yamaguchi 21-17, 21-17 to win the Japan Open women's singles title and become the first Indian to lift the prestigious tournament.

The 31-year-old delivered one of her finest performances in recent years, combining sharp attacking play with disciplined tactics to secure her maiden Super 750 title. The victory also ended a title drought of nearly two years and marked her biggest triumph since winning the World Championships in 2019.

An emotional Sindhu said the victory meant a great deal after a long wait for



Defense Minister Rajnath Singh, unseen, congratulates PV Sindhu after she clinched her maiden Super 750 title at the Japan Open

another title.

"I'm very happy, I'm just out of words because it was 19 months since I had won," she

said after the final.

"I think this one was very important to me because playing in the finals, coming to

the finals is one thing but I think to win and stand on the podium getting that gold is a different thing."

"I'm happy that I'm on the positive side and I think this gives me a lot of confidence. I think I'm very thankful to my coach, my parents, my support staff and of course my husband."

Sindhu's last title came at the Syed Modi International in 2024, while her previous major success on the BWF World Tour was the Singapore Super 500 title in 2022.

The victory was particularly significant given her recent record against Yamaguchi. The Japanese star, playing in her sixth Japan Open final, had not lost a completed match to Sindhu in four years. Their meeting at the Malaysia Open earlier

Continued on P4

AHEAD OF MONSOON SESSION

CJP March Call: Section 163 imposed; security tightened

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Security has been stepped up across the New Delhi district ahead of the Monsoon session of Parliament and the Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) proposed "Chalo Sansad" march on Monday, with the Delhi Police imposing prohibitory orders under Section 163 of the BNSS.

The heightened vigil comes as the CJP announced the march in protest against alleged NEET irregularities and to demand the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan

Deputy Commissioner of Police (DCP) Sachin Sharma shared a public advisory on X on Sunday, stating that the "Delhi Police categorically clarifies that no permission has been sought or granted for any such protest march/procession." The prohibitory order under Section 163 BNSS (formerly Section 144 CrPC) is currently in effect in the New Delhi district, according to the DCP's post. "Accordingly, protest marches, processions, demonstrations and assemblies of five or more persons are strictly prohibited, except at the designated protest site at Jantar Mantar, with prior permission," the post read.

The DCP warned that any person violating these prohibi-



Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) supporters gather during a protest demanding Union Education Min Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation

tory orders could face prosecution under Section 223 BNS and other applicable laws.

"Delhi Police appeals to all citizens to respect the law, refrain from participating in any unauthorised gathering or march, and cooperate in maintaining public peace, safety and security," his post read.

To ensure safety, the Delhi Police has deployed additional personnel, strengthened barricades, and intensified vehicle checks at key entry points, sources said on Sunday.

Police sources mentioned that the CJP has not obtained permission for the proposed march. "We are determined not to allow any unauthorised march towards the high-security zone," they said.

Preventive deployment will remain in place throughout the Parliament session, police added. Several entry points have been converted into high-security zones with multi-layered barricades, enhanced surveillance, anti-sabotage checks and round-the-clock patrolling in New Delhi, Central Delhi and parts of North Delhi, they said.

A senior police source said elaborate preventive arrangements have been made to ensure law and order during the Parliament session.

"Every vehicle entering the New Delhi district is being thoroughly checked. Additional pickets have been set up at strategic locations, and reserve forces have been kept on standby. CCTV surveillance

KEY POINTS

- » Preventive deployment will remain in place throughout the Parliament session
- » Police are maintaining constant surveillance in and around the protest site
- » 'We are determined not to allow any unauthorised march towards the high-security zone': Police



has also been intensified across sensitive areas," the source said.

"Security has been significantly stepped up in and around Jantar Mantar, with a three-tier security arrangement put in place to maintain law and order. Two layers of Delhi Police personnel and one layer of paramilitary forces have been deployed in the area. The security grid will remain in place round the clock to ensure that the situation remains peaceful," the source said.

Police are maintaining constant surveillance in and around the protest site, while additional personnel have been stationed at strategic locations. Adequate arrangements have been made to respond to any law-and-order situation, the

source added.

Security has been strengthened around Jantar Mantar, Parliament Street, Central Vista, Connaught Place, Shankar Chowk and other key installations, while rapid response teams have been positioned to respond to any contingency.

The heightened vigil comes amid fresh developments at the protest site, where CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke continued his indefinite hunger strike after activist Sonam Wangchuk was whisked away on Saturday to the Safdarjung Hospital following deterioration in his health.

Wangchuk issued a message from the hospital urging supporters to participate in the proposed July 20 march.

Man fatally stabs wife over suspicion of affair; nabbed

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A man was arrested in Moradabad for allegedly stabbing his 45-year-old wife to death with scissors following a domestic dispute at their Seelampur home here, stemming from his suspicion that she was having an illicit relationship, police said on Sunday.

After receiving information about the incident around 7:32 pm on July 16 from Seelampur's Gautampuri, police sent a team to the house in north-east Delhi. The team found the woman lying in a pool of blood with grievous injuries.

Police said she was rushed to Jag Pravesh Chandra Hospital, where doctors declared her brought dead. A case was registered at Seelampur police station, and the crime team and the Forensic Science Laboratory (FSL) inspected the spot



“She was rushed to Jag Pravesh Chandra Hosp, where doctors declared her brought dead”

and collected forensic evidence, they said. Police said during the investigation, 52-year-old Saleem was found missing from the house immediately after the incident, making him the prime suspect.

A police team analysed

CCTV footage, examined technical evidence, developed human intelligence and tracked the suspect's movements across several locations. Saleem was traced near Moradabad railway station in Uttar Pradesh and was arrested from there on Saturday, police said.

"During interrogation, the accused confessed to the crime and told investigators that he suspected his wife of having an illicit relationship with a former co-worker at a garment factory, which led to frequent quarrels between them," said the police officer.

On the day of the incident, the couple argued again over the issue.

Police said the accused then attacked her with a pair of scissors before locking the house and fleeing. The weapon and blood-stained clothes have been recovered. Police said further investigation is underway.

Father rapes minor daughter; absconds

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 14-year-old girl was allegedly raped by her father at their home in northwest Delhi's Jahangirpuri area, an officer said on Sunday. Police have registered a case under the relevant sections of the BNS and provisions of the POCSO Act. The accused, police said, remained absconding.

According to the FIR filed at Mahendra Park police station, the survivor said that on July 7, her father raped her when her mother and 10-year-old brother were away. She alleged that he established forcible physical relations with

her against her will and threatened to kill her and her mother if she revealed the incident to anyone. Police have booked the accused under Sections 64(2) (punishment for rape), 65(1) (rape) and 351(3) (criminal intimidation) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, along with Section 6 of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act. The complainant resides with her mother and brother in Jahangirpuri, while her father lives at the Badli village. "The accused is on the run. Multiple teams have been formed to trace and apprehend him at the earliest," a senior police officer said.

Further investigation is underway.

Police nab three for duping man of Rs 5.8 lakh in sextortion scam

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police's Cyber Cell has arrested three alleged cyber fraudsters for duping a man of Rs 5.8 lakh in a sextortion case, officials said.

The arrests were made following a complaint registered at the Cyber Police Station in northeast Delhi. The accused have been identified as Imran (23), son of Kayyum; Kunal (22), son of late Pappu; and Rajesh (18), son of Rajkumar, all residents of Faridabad in Haryana.

Police registered an e-FIR under relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) after a Ganga Vihar resident alleged he had been blackmailed using an obscene video.

According to investigators, the complainant received a WhatsApp video call on May 6 from an unknown woman who impersonated one of his social media friends. During the call, she allegedly recorded an objectionable video without his knowledge.

Soon afterwards, the victim began receiving calls from multiple numbers. The callers allegedly posed as police officials, social media representatives and government authorities, threatening to circulate the video online, implicate him in criminal proceedings and have him arrested unless he paid money.

Fearing the consequences, the complainant transferred around Rs 5.8 lakh in several instalments through different

bank accounts, UPI IDs and QR codes before realising he had been defrauded.

A police team led by Inspector Rahul Kumar, Station House Officer of the Cyber Police Station, conducted a financial and technical investigation that traced part of the defrauded money to mule bank accounts linked to Rajesh and Kunal. Rajesh was arrested on June 17, following which Kunal was apprehended. Based on Kunal's disclosure, Imran, who allegedly withdrew the cheated money from ATMs, was also arrested. Police recovered a mobile phone allegedly used in the crime. During interrogation, the accused allegedly disclosed links to a Rajasthan-based organised sextortion syndicate.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 42-year-old patient died around three hours after a ceiling fan allegedly fell on him inside the emergency ward of Delhi's Guru Teg Bahadur (GTB) Hospital, prompting his family to demand an inquiry into the incident.

Hospital sources said the Public Works Department (PWD) repaired the fan after the incident. They also said a male nurse sustained injuries and was provided medical assistance. However, they added that further details would be available only after an official report is prepared.

Eyewitnesses, however, alleged that the nurse had been injured in a separate incident a few months ago and not dur-

“The death certificate attributed the cause of death to his underlying medical conditions, sources said”

ing the current episode. The incident took place around 9.30 pm on Saturday in Emergency Ward-27, where Mohammad Akbar had been undergoing treatment for the past four to five days, sources said. According to eyewitnesses, the ceiling fan suddenly came loose and fell directly onto the patient's bed, striking Akbar in the abdomen. He was immediately attended to by hospital staff.

Akbar, who was admitted to the hospital on July 17, was suffering from multiple serious ailments, including hypertension, meningoencephalitis and

bed leading to his death.

Several attendants in the ward claimed that many air-conditioners in the ward were either not functioning or had missing parts, leaving ceiling fans as the primary source of ventilation amid the humid weather. Family members of patients expressed anger over the incident and questioned the condition of facilities at the government-run hospital. "Is this the kind of treatment patients are getting?" an attendant said.

Another attendant alleged that his brother had earlier been administered an incorrect needle, which was later replaced by hospital staff. "First, they put the wrong needle in his hand and then came back and changed it," he claimed.

Woman killed after construction machine falls on her in Begampur

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 45-year-old woman was killed on Sunday in the Begumpur area after a heavy concrete slab-lifting machine being used at an under-construction building fell on her as she stepped out of her house to buy milk for breakfast, police said.

The victim, Manju, was passing by the site when the machine suddenly collapsed, killing her on the spot, they said.

Eyewitnesses alleged that the accident could have been avoided if the building owner had implemented basic safety measures, including barricades, warning signs and arrangements to protect pedestrians at the site.

After receiving information, police reached the spot, shifted the body for post-mortem and initiated an investigation to ascertain the circumstances leading to the fatal accident.

Child safety in focus at Delhi Police School

NEW DELHI: As part of Child Safety Awareness Month, Delhi Police Public School, New Police Lines, organised a parent-teacher meeting on July 18 for parents of students in Classes IX to XII. The session focused on strengthening parent-school collaboration to ensure children's safety and well-being.

Teachers discussed attendance, safe transport, personal and cyber safety, bullying prevention, emotional well-being, emergency contacts and child protection measures. Parents were urged to maintain regular communication with the school and were briefed on its child protection initiatives.



DU UG ADMISSIONS

Over 81,900 candidates accept seats in 1st round

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: More than 81,900 candidates have accepted the undergraduate seats allotted to them by the University of Delhi under the first round of the Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS).

Over 21,500 have confirmed their admissions after fee payment, according to updated data released by the varsity on Sunday.

The university said 81,979 of the 93,033 candidates allotted seats in the first round had accepted their allocation as of 2 pm on Sunday, taking the acceptance rate to 88.12 per cent.

Of these, 33,383 candidates had reached the stage where payment links had been generated after college verification, while 21,530 had completed the admission process by paying the requisite fees. This accounts for 23.14 per cent of the total allocations.

The figures mark an increase from Saturday evening, when 79,404 candidates had accepted their allotted seats, 26,061 applications had been approved for fee payment, and 10,746 candidates had completed the admission process.

The first allocation list, announced on July 16, offered



seats to 93,033 candidates against more than 71,000 undergraduate seats across 221 programmes in 67 colleges for the 2026-27 academic session.

The allocations were made from among over 2.08 lakh candidates who completed Phase 2 of the admission process by submitting their programme and college preferences.

Candidates who have accepted their allotted seats can opt for an upgrade in subsequent rounds if they wish to be considered for a higher preference. The second allocation list is scheduled to be released on July 25.

The university said admissions to its two-year postgraduate programmes have reached 10,248, with the first Spot Round of PG admissions set to begin from July 25.

The new academic session is scheduled to commence on July 28.

Two steal gemstones worth Rs 22L from trader; arrested

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Two people, including an e-rickshaw driver, have been arrested for allegedly stealing a bag containing gemstones worth around Rs 22 lakh from a trader here, police said on Sunday. The theft occurred on July

15 near Rani Jhansi Road in Central Delhi after a Jaipur-based gemstone trader told police that his handbag containing nine pouches of precious stones was stolen while he was travelling in an e-rickshaw from Karol Bagh to Daryaganj.

An FIR was registered at the

DBG Road police station, and police launched an investigation.

After scanning CCTV footage, police identified and arrested the accused, Vicky Solanki (19), the e-rickshaw driver and Anita alias Annu (26), near Dhaula Kuan on July 17, the officer said. During interrogation, the

accused confessed to the crime and disclosed where they had concealed the stolen gemstones, leading to the recovery of around 90 per cent of the valuables. Police said the e-rickshaw used in the offence was seized and an investigation is underway to recover the remaining gemstones.

Long waits, full shelters force AIIMS families onto pavements

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: At 3 am, the pavement outside AIIMS Delhi is still awake. Children sleep on cardboard sheets, attendants curl up on chairs inside overcrowded cooling tents, and hundreds wait through the night not because they have nowhere else to go, but because they fear losing their place in the queue when OPD registrations begin.

For many families, sleeping outside AIIMS has become a necessity shaped by poverty, distance and the country's overburdened healthcare system.

Dinesh Beniwal, who has travelled from Haryana for his brother's cancer treatment, said he has been visiting AIIMS for nearly a year. "AIIMS is the best and the cheapest. Vishram Sadans are usually full. We don't sleep on the foot-



path by choice; this is our major problem. There is a job crisis. Why would we spend money on a room when we need it for treatment?" he said.

He also alleged that attendants are often asked to leave waiting areas inside the hospital even if they briefly fall asleep while waiting for patients.

A tea vendor outside the hospital offered a different perspective. While acknowledging the lack of space, he said some people choose to stay outside so they can join the unofficial queue that begins around 4

Beniwal alleged that attendants are often asked to leave waiting areas inside the hospital even if they briefly fall asleep while waiting for patients

a.m., hours before OPD registration officially opens at 8 a.m.

The investigation found that the AIIMS Vishram Sadans remain largely occupied, while three government-supported cooling tents outside, equipped with coolers, drinking water and chairs provided with support from the Delhi Government and NDMC, the shelters had no beds, forcing many children and attendants to sleep on floors and chairs. NDMC officials were also seen supplying water tankers



according to demand.

AIIMS officials said they introduced Vishram Sadans on December 21, 2024, to move people away from pavements. "We are also afraid seeing people sleep outside. A rash driver could harm them," an official said. They said CRPF personnel assist with security, NGOs help provide food, Ashray Sadans cater to OPD patients free of cost, while Vishram Sadans offer low-cost accommodation and pantry facilities for attendants.

Combined with the Jhajjar

Private school’s seven-day test

Govt issues show cause notice to private school in Janakpuri, proposes takeover

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has issued a show-cause notice to the management of a private school in Janakpuri, citing serious allegations of child safety lapses, unauthorised operations and financial irregularities. The Directorate of Education (DoE) has proposed a government takeover of the school’s management if the institution fails to respond satisfactorily within seven days.

Education Minister Ashish Sood said the government would adopt a zero-tolerance approach towards any compromise on children’s safety and welfare. “Our government has absolute zero tolerance for any compromise on the safety and dignity of our children. A

school stands in loco parentis, it is legally and morally responsible for every child on its premises. If an institution covers up a heinous crime like child abuse, operates illegal branches in residential basements, and loots public funds, we will not sit quietly. We are prepared to completely take over the management and recommend the cancellation of their land lease,” Sood said.

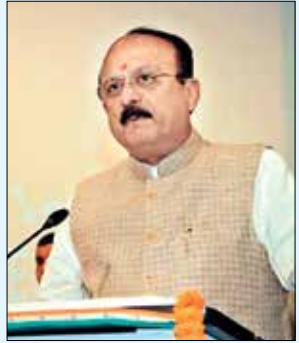
According to the government, a multi-phase inquiry by specialised DoE committees found that the school allegedly failed to report the alleged sexual molestation of a nursery student on April 30, 2026, to the Directorate of Education, despite mandatory child protection requirements.

The inquiry also found that

SCHOOL UNDER FIRE

» Education Minister Ashish Sood said the government would adopt a zero-tolerance approach towards any compromise on children’s safety and welfare

» A multi-phase inquiry by specialised DoE committees found that the school allegedly failed to report the alleged sexual molestation of a nursery student on April 30, 2026, to the Directorate of Education, despite mandatory child protection requirements



all 64 CCTV cameras at the pre-primary branch were non-functional when police visited the campus to investigate the incident. Officials alleged that the school had been operat-

ing without a CCTV maintenance contract. The DoE further alleged that the school was running nursery and kindergarten classes from an unauthorised residential building in Narang Colony, where the basement was being used as an activity area for children without approval.

The inspection also reportedly found the absence of a Child Protection Policy, Child Protection Committee and a POCISO-trained nodal officer. In addition, security personnel had allegedly not undergone mandatory police verification.

Officials further alleged that the school’s Fire No Objection Certificate had expired in 2020 and had not been renewed, while parents were compelled to send multiple water bottles due to inad-

equate drinking water facilities. The inquiry also flagged alleged financial irregularities, including the diversion of nearly Rs 6 crore earmarked for staff retirement benefits to another branch, delayed payment of salaries, and a 15 per cent fee hike for the 2025-26 academic session, which the government said was in violation of court directions.

The show-cause notice proposes a government takeover of the school under Section 20(1) of the Delhi School Education Act, 1973, recommends cancellation of the school’s land lease by the Delhi Development Authority, and calls for criminal proceedings under the POCSO Act and the Juvenile Justice Act. The school has been given seven days to submit its response.

‘HAR GHAR TIRANGA’ CAMPAIGN Delhi to source 2 lakh tricolours from SHGs

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government will source around 2 lakh tricolours from self-help groups (SHGs) for distribution under the ‘Har Ghar Tiranga’ campaign ahead of Independence Day, according to a statement issued by the chief minister’s office on Sunday.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said more than 15 lakh national flags will be distributed across Delhi as part of the campaign.

To promote public participation, patriotism and national unity, SHGs across Delhi have been given an important role in the campaign. Around 2 lakh national flags will be produced through eligible SHGs identified by the State Urban Livelihood Mission, she said.

Gupta said the Delhi government is committed to making the campaign a success through the involvement of every section of society while also creating opportunities for the economic empowerment of SHGs.

The government said all flags produced by the SHGs would strictly comply with the Flag Code of India, 2002, its amendments issued from time to time, the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971, and the prescribed technical standards.

This is to ensure that every



“More than 15 lakh national flags will be distributed across Delhi as part of the campaign — CM GUPTA

national flag reflects the dignity, honour and national pride associated with the Tricolour, the CMO said.

The government will also procure national flags from online marketplaces to ensure that the spirit of the ‘Har Ghar Tiranga’ campaign reaches every household in Delhi, it added.

Speaker Gupta named to AIPOC committee

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Legislative Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta has been nominated as a member of a high-level committee constituted by the All India Presiding Officers’ Conference (AIPOC) to develop a National Legislative Index, an initiative aimed at benchmarking the performance of legislative bodies across the country using objective parameters.

The committee has been constituted following the adoption of Resolution No. 6 during the 86th All India Presiding Officers’ Conference, held in Lucknow, Uttar Pradesh, from January 19 to 21, 2026, under the chairmanship of the Speaker of the Lok Sabha.

According to an official communication issued by Sreekanth S., Director, Parliament House Annexe, New Delhi, the Lok Sabha Speaker, who is also the Chairperson of AIPOC, has approved the constitution of the committee to create the National Legislative Index.

The initiative seeks to benchmark the functioning of legislatures across the country “on the basis of objective parameters, with a view to fostering a conducive environment for



healthy competition for serving the public interest with greater accountability.”

Rajya Sabha Deputy Chairman Harivansh has been appointed as the chairperson of the committee. Apart from Gupta, the panel comprises Speakers of the legislative assemblies of Uttar Pradesh, Nagaland, Odisha, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Telangana and Tamil Nadu.

The committee includes Uttar Pradesh Speaker Satish Mahana, Nagaland Speaker Sharingin Longkumer, Odisha Speaker Surama Padhy, Bihar Speaker Prem Kumar, Madhya Pradesh Speaker Narendra Singh Tomar, Maharashtra Speaker Rahul Narwekar, Telangana Speaker Gaddam Prasad Kumar and Tamil Nadu Speaker J.C.D. Prabhakar.

DDA achieves nearly 30% of mega plantation target

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: Under the guidance of Lieutenant Governor of Delhi Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu, the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) has made significant progress in its Mega Plantation Drive across the national capital, planting more than 6.62 lakh saplings within the first few days of the campaign. The plantations include over 37,000 trees and more than 6.25 lakh shrubs, taking the authority close to 30 per cent of its overall plantation target.



The plantation project is being implemented in line with the Lieutenant Governor’s emphasis on ecological restoration, environmental sustainability and the expansion of Delhi’s green infrastructure. The progress of the drive is being closely monitored to ensure effective implementation and long term survival of the plantations. The Lieutenant Governor has also directed departments to maintain constant monitoring so that the saplings planted survive.

The ongoing drive began in the first week of July and will continue till mid September 2026, focusing on native and climate resilient species. Apart

from enhancing biodiversity, the initiative aims to strengthen carbon sequestration, improve microclimatic regulation and enhance ecological connectivity across Delhi’s green systems. It is also expected to improve air quality, support groundwater recharge, create habitats and enhance overall urban livability.

On July 7, Union Home and Cooperation Minister Amit Shah launched the Mission 70 lakh plantation drive under the ‘Ek Ped Maa ke Naam’ campaign in Delhi, which includes DDA’s target of planting 23 lakh saplings.

The plantation drive is being carried out across 675 DDA parks, four Ridge areas, six biodiversity parks, identified intervention zones and green corridors. DDA has also partnered with RWAs, educational institutions, religious organisations, volunteer groups and corporate institutions to encourage public participation and foster shared ownership of Delhi’s green assets. The authority said it remains committed to achieving its target of nearly 23 lakh native saplings this plantation season through sustained afforestation and landscape restoration initiatives.

Smart electric substation of 2,000 kVA capacity opens in east Delhi

NEW DELHI: Union Minister of State Harsh Malhotra and Delhi power minister Ashish Sood inaugurated BSES’ first-of-its-kind smart pad-mounted substation as well as the ‘Solarize East’ campaign in east Delhi on Sunday.

The pad-mounted substation in Gandhi Nagar has the capacity to deliver full-scale power in nearly 80 per cent less space. It’s an innovative space-saving solution that brings 2,000 kVA capacity to the heart of one of Delhi’s most congested markets, said a BSES statement.

‘Solarize East’, launched under the PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana, will enable consumers to realise the full benefits of the central government scheme and the Delhi Solar Policy by promoting a community-led initiative.

Speaking on the occasion, Malhotra stressed that the Delhi government is working diligently to meet the futuristic and ever-growing power demand of the national capital. He further stressed that these two initiatives by BSES are the right steps in this direction. Delhi Power Minister Sood said, “Every substation we modernise and every rooftop we solarise is a step towards a stronger, greener, and more self-reliant.”

Delhi government’s Rs 1,427 crore investment in power infrastructure and the successful management of the record peak power demand of 8,748 MW without major outages.”

Smart substation & solar drive launched

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Delhi Power Minister Ashish Sood on Sunday launched two initiatives to modernise the Capital’s power infrastructure and promote clean energy. He inaugurated a Smart Pad Mounted Substation at Gandhi Nagar and rolled out the “Solarize East” campaign to boost rooftop solar adoption under the PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana.

Speaking at the event, Sood said the Delhi government had invested Rs 1,427 crore in power sector capital expenditure over the past year to strengthen transmission and distribution networks, build new substations, modernise ageing infrastructure and deploy smart technologies.

Highlighting Delhi’s record peak power demand of 8,748 MW this year, he said the city met the highest-ever demand without any major outage, attributing it to better planning and stronger infrastruc-

ture. “Our goal is not merely to supply electricity, but to ensure reliable, affordable, smart and green power,” he said.

The newly inaugurated Smart Pad Mounted Substation occupies nearly 80 per cent less space than conventional substations and is equipped with SCADA technology for real-time monitoring, faster fault detection and improved power reliability, making it suitable for densely populated areas.

Sood said the “Solarize East” campaign aims to encourage households to install rooftop solar systems by providing information on subsidies, net metering and installation under the PM Surya Ghar scheme. The campaign will initially cover South-East Delhi before being expanded to other BYPL distribution areas.

Union Minister of State Harsh Malhotra, local legislators, councillors, RWAs, housing society representatives and BYPL officials attended the launch.

A SWEET STOP



A plain tiger butterfly feeds on the nectar of a flower, in Gurugram, on Sunday

PTI

City records warmest July night in five years

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: With the minimum temperature of 31 degrees Celsius on Sunday, Delhi recorded the warmest July night in five years, according to the India Meteorological Department.

The city had logged a minimum temperature of 31.7 degrees Celsius on July 1, 2021.

The maximum temperature logged at the Safdarjung, Delhi’s base station, was 38.3 degrees Celsius, 3.1 notches above the seasonal average, according to the IMD. The minimum was 3.8 notches above the season’s average. It was also the second instance this month of the minimum temperature touching 31 degrees, after a similar reading was recorded on Friday.

Among the weather stations in Delhi, Palam recorded 37.6 degrees Celsius, Ayanagar 37.2 degrees Celsius, Lodhi Road 36.7 degrees Celsius and Ridge at 36.6 degrees Celsius.

The minimum temperature at Lodhi Road was 30 degrees

Celsius, Ayanagar 29.4 degrees Celsius, Palam 29 degrees Celsius and Ridge 27.6 degrees Celsius.

No rainfall was recorded at any of the five observatories between 8.30 am and 5.30 pm on Sunday.

The weather department has predicted a generally cloudy sky with moderate rain on Monday, with the maximum and minimum temperatures expected to settle around 36 degrees Celsius and 26 degrees Celsius, respectively, the IMD said.

Relative humidity oscillated between 68 per cent at 8.30 am and 50 per cent at 5.30 pm.

The air quality was recorded in the ‘moderate’ category at 4 pm, with an Air Quality Index (AQI) reading of 169, the Sameer app showed.

According to the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB), an AQI between zero and 50 is considered ‘good’, 51 and 100 ‘satisfactory’, 101 and 200 ‘moderate’, 201 and 300 ‘poor’, 301 and 400 ‘very poor’, and 401 and 500 ‘severe’.

Clean-up goes electric

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) inducted 135 electric sanitation vehicles into its fleet, a move aimed at strengthening door-to-door waste collection and expanding the city’s sanitation infrastructure.

The vehicles were flagged off by Delhi Mayor Praveesh Wahi at Sector 10, Rohini. Of the total fleet, 46 vehicles have been deployed in the Rohini Zone, while the remaining will serve the Narela, Civil Lines and Keshav Puram zones. Local councillors, Rohini Zone Deputy Commissioner Anshul Sirohi and senior MCD officials were present at the event.

Addressing the gathering, Wahi said the induction of electric sanitation vehicles would mark a significant step towards improving waste management while reducing dependence on conventional fuel. He said the vehicles have been introduced under the Delhi Government’s newly launched Electric Vehicle Policy, aligning with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta’s vision of building a cleaner and greener capital.

The Mayor said the expansion of sanitation infrastructure reflects the civic body’s efforts to modernise waste collection systems across Delhi. He added that sanitation resources are being strengthened in a planned manner across all MCD zones to improve operational efficiency and enhance cleanliness.



“Expansion of sanitation infrastructure reflects the civic body’s efforts to modernise waste collection systems across Delhi — MAYOR

ery, enabling improvements in cleanliness operations across the city.

Highlighting the importance of waste segregation, the Mayor urged residents to comply with the Solid Waste Management Rules by separating waste into four categories at the source. Proper segregation and on-site disposal of wet waste, he said, would help reduce the volume of garbage reaching Delhi’s land-fill sites.

Stressing that sanitation is a shared responsibility, Wahi called for active public participation in keeping the capital clean. He said the addition of electric vehicles would make the door-to-door waste collection system more efficient while contributing to Delhi’s transition towards environmentally sustainable urban services.

TO PROMOTE CITIZEN PARTICIPATION Delhi zoo launches ‘Sunday Spider & Insect Walk’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The National Zoological Park (NZP) on Sunday launched its ‘Sunday Spider and Insect Walk at NZP’, a citizen science initiative aimed at encouraging public participation in documenting biodiversity and creating awareness about the ecological importance of spiders and insects.

The inaugural walk, held from 7 to 10 am, drew 30 participants, including nature

enthusiasts, students, wildlife photographers and biodiversity researchers, a statement said.

The programme was led by naturalist and wildlife photographer Ashir Kumar, along with volunteers and zoo officials, it stated.

During the walk, participants documented seven spider species and eight insect species, recording observations of more than 1,000 individual spiders and insects across the zoo campus, it said.

The activity also introduced participants to scientific methods of species identification and biodiversity documentation.

Among the spider species recorded were the Twin-tailed Spider, Thin-Legged Wolf Spider, Heavy-Bodied Jumper, Two-Striped Jumper, Spotted Orb-Weaver, Pantropical Jumping Spider and Banded Phintella. Insects documented included the Stink Bug, Paper Wasp, Carpenter Bee, Hover Fly, Ladybird Beetle and Ghost Ant.

Addressing participants, Kumar explained the ecological role of spiders and insects as natural pest controllers, pollinators and decomposers, while highlighting their contribution to maintaining healthy ecosystems. He also encouraged participants to contribute to biodiversity conservation through citizen science.

The programme concluded with an interactive discussion, a feedback session and a group photograph. Zoo officials said

the initiative aims to build environmental awareness while generating valuable biodiversity records through community participation.

On the same day, the zoo also organised the sixth edition of its ‘Sunday Bird Walk at NZP’, during which participants recorded 46 bird species.

Officials said participation in each Sunday walk is restricted to 20-25 people to ensure a better learning experience, it read.

J&K FLOODS

CM Omar seeks six-hourly situation reports from all districts till July 24

OUR CORRESPONDENT

JAMMU: In view of the prevailing weather conditions in Jammu and Kashmir, Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Sunday directed all district administrations to submit situation reports every six hours until July 24 to strengthen monitoring and ensure a coordinated response.

Abdullah passed the directive at a high-level meeting at the Civil Secretariat here to review the situation arising from incessant rainfall leading to flash floods in Poonch and Rajouri.

At least 12 people were killed and several others missing as torrential rains unleashed landslides and flash floods across the twin border districts of Poonch and Rajouri on Sunday, causing widespread damage to public and private infrastructure including roads and houses.

The chief minister also assessed the preparedness of the administration to deal with any weather-related eventuality across Jammu and Kashmir.

To strengthen monitoring during the ongoing weather

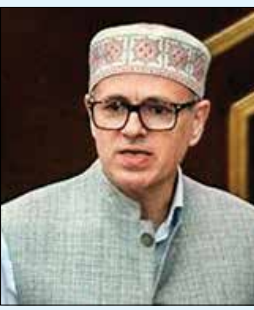
HIGHLIGHTS

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» The chief minister also assessed the preparedness of the administration to deal with any weather-related eventuality across Jammu and Kashmir



conditions, the chief minister directed that, beginning today and till July 24, every district shall submit situation reports every six hours to the respective divisional commissioner, who will consolidate and forward the reports to Department of Disaster Management, Relief, Rehabilitation

& Reconstruction. “The department will compile the reports and circulate them to the offices of the Lieutenant Governor, the Chief Minister, the Chief Secretary and the Ministry of Home Affairs, Government of India,” Abdullah said, expressing hope that the reporting

mechanism could be discontinued after July 24 if weather conditions improve.

The meeting comprehensively reviewed the prevailing weather situation, the impact of heavy rainfall, flash floods and landslides reported from different parts of Jammu and Kashmir, and the measures being undertaken by various departments to ensure public safety, restore essential services and provide timely relief to affected families, an official spokesman said. Expressing condolences to the families who lost their loved ones in the flash floods, the chief minister said the government stands firmly with every affected family and remains committed to providing all possible assistance for relief, rehabilitation and restoration.

Abdullah was informed that rescue teams have already been kept on alert in rain-affected areas to respond to any eventuality.

He stressed that every possible effort should be made to trace and retrieve missing persons so that affected families receive timely support and they are able to reconcile with the reality of unfor-

tunate death of their loved ones.

Reviewing the availability of essential commodities across J&K, Abdullah directed the concerned departments to ensure uninterrupted supplies of food grains, medicines, drinking water and other essential items in every district.

He also called for the expeditious restoration of roads, power supply, drinking water schemes and communication links wherever these have been disrupted due to heavy rains.

At the meeting, the chief minister was also informed that sufficient funds have been kept available to meet relief and rehabilitation requirements wherever necessary.

He directed that there should be no delay in extending financial assistance and relief to affected families.

The meeting was informed that adequate stocks of medicines are available across J&K while surveillance has been intensified to prevent any outbreak of water-borne or communicable diseases in the aftermath of heavy rains.

AAIB AFFIDAVIT: AI-171 crash victims’ kin seek black box data

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

AHMEDABAD: Families of those killed in the AI-171 flight crash here on Sunday demanded that the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) make the black box data and cockpit voice recorder (CVR) transcript public or share them with their lawyers.

They also questioned the agency’s decision to “withhold” the material while promising only a final investigation report.

The London Gatwick Air India flight AI-171 crashed shortly after takeoff from Ahmedabad’s Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel International Airport on June 12, 2025, resulting in India’s deadliest aviation disaster in decades.

The Boeing 787 Dreamliner plunged into the BJ Medical College hostel complex, killing 241 of the 242 passengers on board and 19 people on the ground.

Representatives of the victims’ families met here to discuss the AAIB’s recent affidavit before the Supreme Court, in which the agency said it would not release the black box data or the CVR transcript.

They also demanded greater transparency in the probe, a memorial at the crash site and the significance of simulator tests in the ongoing investigation.

Addressing reporters after the meeting, Romin Vahora, who lost his brother, niece and aunt in the tragedy, questioned how portions of the cockpit conversation had surfaced soon after the crash if the authorities believed such material should not be made public.

“If they never intended to release the data, why did they release a cockpit voice recording transcript (as part of preliminary report) just a few days after the crash?” Vahora asked, claiming that the families wanted to know whether the selective disclosure was meant to “shift the blame onto the pilots or mislead the victims’ families”.

He said the families wanted the raw black box data to be released publicly, handed over to the families or shared with the lawyers representing them.

“If they only give us a summarised report, what guarantee do we have that it is accurate? Until the actual black box data is released, nobody can definitively assure us whether the report is true or false,” said Vahora, a resident of Kheda district. Vahora said the families had not yet initiated any legal proceedings and were waiting for the final investigation report, while their lawyers were pursuing all legal avenues to obtain the black box data.

He said the families would

continue efforts to obtain the black box data, stressing there was no clear reason for withholding it when similar information had been released in investigations of several previous air crashes.

He added that if the report was not released by the timeline indicated in the AAIB affidavit, the families would consider holding protests after obtaining permission from the authorities.

Earlier this week, the AAIB told the Supreme Court that the draft final report of its probe into the aviation tragedy was expected to be ready in October this year.

In a detailed affidavit, it also said that sensitive investigative material, including witness statements, cockpit voice recorder recordings and transcripts, air traffic control communications, and medical information, needed to be kept confidential as their disclosure could adversely affect the integrity of the ongoing investigation and future aviation safety inquiries. The victims’ families on Sunday also reiterated their demand for a permanent memorial at the AI171 crash site. Vahora urged the government, Air India and the Tata Group, which owns the carrier, to earmark land and allocate funds for a monument honouring the victims.

From Page 1

Parl braces for stormy

to dominate the upcoming session.

Explaining the Opposition’s protest, TMC MP Mahua Moitra said all INDIA bloc parties, including the Congress, Samajwadi Party, DMK, Jharkhand Mukti Morcha, Aam Aadmi Party, National Conference, Left parties and Shiv Sena (UBT), had walked out in protest against the presence of the “so-called NCPI”, which she described as an unrecognised party.

The Monsoon session will open in the shadow of several raging issues like the planned march to Parliament by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) on Monday and the row over the alleged embezzlement of donations at the Ram temple in Ayodhya. Both issues have been used by the opposition to target the government, which, according to sources, is also likely to be in a “combative mode” and its “priority” would be the passage of bills during the session.

The CJP, which has been holding a sit-in at Jantar Mantar, barely couple of kilometers from the Parliament House, on Saturday escalated its protest for the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the alleged NEET paper leak after police whisked away activist Sonam Wangchuk to hospital on the 21st day of his hunger strike.

The stage for confrontation on the delimitation-women reservation agenda was set this week after Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge wrote to Prime Minister Narendra Modi for an all-party meeting.

With BJP-led NDA strategists actively working to shore up a two-thirds majority required to pass the Constitution Amendment Bill to implement women’s reservation and delimitation of constituencies, the principal opposition Congress is planning to mount a counter-offensive.

Although the Congress is confident that INDIA-bloc parties will continue to oppose the bill, several opposition parties, including NCP-SP and Shiv Sena (UBT), have already indicated they are open to the government move should adequate safeguards for states be incorporated in the draft law.

Even the DMK, which strongly opposed the Constitution 131st amendment bill defeated in the special session in April, has said that it will react to the new draft after reviewing it. The party has parted ways with the Congress and has sought a separate seating arrangement. The government seems determined to make one more bid at piloting and passing the Constitution 131st Amendment Bill 2026, convinced that the opposition faces fractured ranks. Its strength is bolstered by 20 TMC Lok Sabha MPs and 6 SS-UBT MPs breaking away from their parent parties to support the NDA in Lok Sabha.

The bill, which was defeated in the last session, seeks to reserve 33 per cent seats for women in

Lok Sabha and state assemblies by the 2029 general elections by conducting a delimitation of Lok Sabha seats and raising the house’s strength to accommodate more women. On Saturday, Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla approved the merger of six Shiv Sena-UBT MPs with the Eknath Shinde-led Shiv Sena, a constituent of the ruling NDA. Official sources said that with the merger of the six MPs, the strength of the Shiv Sena has gone up to 13.

The NDA is short of a few seats for a two-thirds majority in the Rajya Sabha, and some abstentions could help pass the Constitution Amendment Bill in the Upper house. Passing a Constitution Amendment Bill requires a two-thirds majority of the members present and voting.

Among the bills the government has listed for consideration and passing in the Monsoon session are some contentious ones, including the FCRA Amendment Bill and the Vikshit Bharat Shiksha Adhishthan Bill.

Other bills to be taken up during the session include making obstruction and insult of the national song Vande Mataram a criminal offence and bills to replace ordinances to increase the strength of Supreme Court judges and grant capital tax exemption to FIs for investing in government bonds.

Congress chief Kharge has already said that the party would raise issues like institutional capture, breaking of political parties, scams and corruption, price rise, foreign policy failures and ethanol blending in petrol, while seeking to corner the government during the session. According to the sources, the government is likely to counter the opposition’s push for a response on alleged embezzlement of donations at Ram Temple in Ayodhya by insisting it is a “state matter”.

INDIA bloc protests NCPI

of the Congress, Samajwadi Party, DMK, JMM, Aam Aadmi Party, National Conference, Left parties and Shiv Sena (UBT). The Opposition later returned to the meeting.

Addressing the media, Mahua questioned the basis for inviting the rebel MPs as NCPI representatives when the Speaker has not formally recognised them as a separate bloc.

“These 20 MPs have not yet been recognised by the Speaker. After the 91st Amendment to the Constitution, there is no provision for a separate bloc,” she said.

Mahua also pointed out that the Lok Sabha website continues to list the TMC’s strength as 28 MPs, while disqualification petitions against the 20 rebel MPs are still pending before Speaker Om Birla.

“So, on what grounds were these rebels invited to the all-party meeting?” she asked.

The protest followed Union Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju’s decision to invite the rebel MPs on Saturday night. The NCPI MPs have also been allotted separate seats in the Lok Sabha after the party sought such an arrangement, a move criticised by Opposition parties.

The Opposition also questioned the Speaker’s decision, citing the recognition of rebel Shiv Sena MPs in Maharashtra. CPI(M) leader John Brittas termed the invitation to the NCPI “against the principles of justice”.

Congress MP Jairam Ramesh wrote on social media: “This was a mark of protest against the decision of the Modi Govt to invite the NCPI that is a parking place for 20 so-called ‘rebel’ TMC MPs when a final decision is still pending with the Speaker.”

Defending the invitation, NCPI leader Sudip Bandyopadhyay said, “The NCPI is recognised by the Election Commission. Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar is going to submit all the documents to the Lok Sabha Speaker soon.”

Backing the move, BJP leader Sukanta Majumder said, “A party that consists of 20 MPs should be invited naturally. Those who want to oppose can oppose anything.”

Delhi HC

Gitanjali Angmo, observing that the government’s decision to shift him from the Jantar Mantar protest site to Safdarjung Hospital could not be termed arbitrary. The court noted that Wangchuk had not admitted himself to any hospital despite being on a prolonged hunger strike and held that the authorities were justified in intervening to protect his health. It also recorded that doctors had only administered sugar-free oral rehydration solution (ORS) and potassium chloride tablets with his consent and that there was no evidence of forced treatment or violation of his bodily autonomy. The Centre has been directed to file its response to the petition within three days.

During the hearing, Senior Advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for Angmo, argued that Wangchuk was neither under arrest nor under any form of detention and therefore had the constitutional right to seek treatment at a hospital of his own choice. He informed the court that Medanta Hospital had agreed to admit Wangchuk and argued that there was no legal basis to keep him at Safdarjung. Sibal also contended that the July 16 High Court order directing medical monitoring did not authorise the authorities to remove Wangchuk from the protest site or restrict access to him.

The Centre opposed the plea, with Additional Solicitor General Chetan Sharma arguing that Wangchuk’s health had deteriorated after nearly three weeks of fasting, making immediate medical intervention necessary. He told the court that specialists from Safdarjung Hospital and AIIMS were jointly monitoring Wangchuk’s condition and urged the family to place confidence in government doctors. Sharma also opposed allowing unrestricted access to lawyers inside the hospital, saying it was a medical facility and not a courtroom.

The court interacted with an AIIMS emergency medicine specialist, who informed the bench that Wangchuk had voluntarily started taking sugar-free ORS and potassium tablets but continued to decline intravenous fluids. According to the doctor, his potassium, sodium and blood sugar levels

were borderline and his body had entered ketosis, requiring close observation.

A discussion also took place on whether doctors should have authority to administer emergency treatment. While the Centre requested the court to clarify that doctors could undertake whatever intervention was necessary to save Wangchuk’s life, Sibal objected, arguing that such an observation could permit treatment without consent. The court eventually left medical decisions to the treating team in accordance with established medical protocols without issuing any direction permitting forced treatment.

Sonam Wangchuk’s message from hospital

Even as the hearing was underway, Wangchuk appealed to supporters through a handwritten message shared by his wife from the hospital, calling the July 20 mobilisation Indians “second freedom movement”. Urging people to ensure the march is a “big success”, he linked the campaign to “freedom from injustice” over alleged examination irregularities and “freedom from fear”, referring to what he described as his “illegal detention” at Safdarjung Hospital.

Wangchuk’s Wife questions intervention; legal battle intensifies

Angmo later said Wangchuk would call off his indefinite hunger strike only if political leaders invited him at Safdarjung Hospital and assured him that the issue of education accountability would be raised during the Monsoon Session of Parliament beginning Monday.

Angmo also raised concerns over discrepancies in Wangchuk’s potassium reports. She claimed that while Safdarjung Hospital informed the family that his potassium level had fallen to 2.9 mmol/L, an independent laboratory later reported a normal reading after testing the same sample, which she said was handed over only after a delay of more than ten hours.

She alleged that the differing reports had undermined the family’s confidence in the hospital’s assessment. The petition further alleges that Wangchuk has been denied unrestricted access to his lawyers and treating doctors, while also claiming that he is being unlawfully confined despite there being no FIR, arrest order or detention order against him.

Outside the courtroom, Dr Angmo questioned the government’s intervention, saying her husband had earlier completed a 35-day fast in Ladakh without requiring hospitalisation. “He has fasted for 35 days in Ladakh. His health is fine. There was no need for government intervention,” she said. She also alleged that the petition had been “wrongly interpreted” and asked why the government could not have acted democratically and with the family’s confidence if intervention was considered necessary.

Crowds swell at Jantar Mantar; opposition backs protest

At Jantar Mantar, meanwhile, the protest entered its fourth week with thousands continuing their sit-in despite humid weather. Students, teachers, parents, job aspirants, working professionals and social activists remained at the protest site through the day, raising slogans and preparing for Monday’s planned Parliament march. Volunteers dis-

tributed drinking water, coordinated crowd movement, managed medical assistance and ensured the demonstration remained peaceful and organised.

“I came because students deserve a fair and transparent education system,” said Ananya Verma, a postgraduate student from Lucknow. “Peaceful protest is our democratic right, and we hope our concerns are heard.”

Mohit Rathi, an engineer from Jaipur, said the movement had expanded beyond student issues. “This is about every family that believes merit should be protected. That’s why people from different professions have come together.”

School teacher Neelam Sharma said education reforms require broad public participation. “We teach young people about democracy and accountability. Standing here peacefully is an extension of those values,” she said.

Parents also joined the demonstration. Ashok Kumar, who travelled from Uttar Pradesh with his son preparing for competitive examinations, said, “We want future generations to have faith in the examination system.”

The protest has also received significant traction online. Several social media influencers and some public personalities have expressed support for the movement, while organisers created multiple WhatsApp groups to coordinate travel, accommodation and logistics for people travelling alone to Delhi. Participants said the digital networks had enabled people from different states to join the protest safely and in larger numbers.

Political reactions also emerged ahead of Parliament’s Monsoon Session. Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray criticised the Union government, questioning why it had not initiated dialogue with Wangchuk in the way the previous UPA government had engaged with anti-corruption activist Anna Hazare during his hunger strike in 2011.

He also questioned attempts to portray Wangchuk negatively despite his contributions to innovation and sustainable development in Ladakh.

Monsoon lashes

Nunwan-Chandanwari base camps in Kashmir as well as from Bhagwati Nagar Yatri Niwas in Jammu. Rain began early Sunday, with cloudbursts reported in forest areas of Kashmir. The weather department has forecast moderate to widespread rainfall across the Union Territory from July 19 to 23.

In Uttarakhand, two people died after being struck by lightning in Haridwar district as continuous rain affected large parts of the state. The administration issued red and orange alerts for 10 districts.

According to the State Emergency Operation Centre, 84 roads, including two national highways, were blocked after landslides triggered by incessant rain. The Meteorological Department warned of heavy to extremely heavy rainfall in several parts of the state over the next few days.

An orange alert has been issued for Dehradun, Tehri, Pauri, Uttarkashi, Rudrapur, Haridwar and

Bageshwar districts, while Chamoli, Almora and Pithoragarh remain under a yellow alert.

In Nagaland, at least three people were killed in flash floods in Mon district. Officials said the floods swept away houses, blocked roads and trapped several people under debris. Authorities warned that the death toll could increase as rescue operations continued and more people were believed to be trapped following flash floods and landslides.

Himachal Pradesh also remained on alert after the Shimla Meteorological Centre forecast very heavy rainfall at isolated places in four to five districts over the next two days. A red warning has been issued for Chamba, Kangra, Mandi and Sirmour districts for Monday, while Chamba, Kangra, Kullu, Mandi and Sirmour districts are expected to receive very heavy rainfall on Tuesday.

The India Meteorological Department has also forecast widespread rain and thunderstorms across Uttar Pradesh during the next 24 hours. Heavy rainfall is likely at a few places, with very heavy rain expected at isolated locations. Thunderstorms accompanied by lightning are also likely in isolated areas.

In West Bengal, the IMD predicted heavy rainfall in the northern districts over the next two days and warned of possible landslides in hilly areas and flash floods in low-lying regions. It said water levels in rivers, including the Teesta, Torsa, Jaldhaka and Raidak, could rise as persistent rain continued to lash Darjeeling, Kalimpong, Jalpaiguri, Alipurduar and Cooch Behar since Saturday. Extremely heavy rain is expected in Jalpaiguri and Alipurduar, while the remaining sub-Himalayan districts are likely to receive very heavy rainfall.

While several states battled heavy rain, Delhi, Haryana and Punjab experienced hot and humid conditions. The IMD said Delhi recorded a minimum temperature of 31 degrees Celsius on Sunday, making it the warmest July night in five years. The city had last recorded a higher July minimum of 31.7 degrees Celsius on July 1, 2021. The maximum temperature at Safdarjung reached 38.3 degrees Celsius, which was 3.1 degrees above normal, while the minimum was 3.8 degrees above the seasonal average. It was the second time this month that Delhi’s minimum temperature touched 31 degrees after a similar reading on Friday. In Punjab, Bathinda recorded the highest maximum temperature at 40.8 degrees Celsius as sultry weather persisted across the state and neighbouring Haryana.

Swear words, profanities

are taken at their face value and accepted to be true in entirety, the same cannot be held to be obscene,” the top court said in a judgment on Friday.

It said that such words, however abusive, unpalatable or uncivil, do not satisfy the requirement of Section 294(b) of IPC.

“It is nobody’s case that use of such words caused annoyance to

others in a public place, which is a mandatory ingredient of the Section, much less to the complainant. In the absence thereof, we find that the offence under Section 294(b) IPC is not made out,” the bench said.

The case related to an agricultural land dispute in Tamil Nadu in August 2017, wherein an argument took place between the petitioner and his brother-in-law.

Two days later, the petitioner allegedly got into another confrontation with the complainant’s nephew over the same property issue. The prosecution claimed that when the complainant stepped in, the petitioner verbally abused him with vulgar expletives and caste-based slurs.

The trial court found the petitioner guilty under Sections 294(b) (obscenity), 326 (grievous hurt) and 506(ii) (criminal intimidation) of the Indian Penal Code, along with provisions of the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act.

The Madras High Court acquitted the petitioner of the charges under the SC/ST Act but confirmed his convictions under the IPC.

PV Sindhu

this year ended after Yamaguchi retired following the opening game. Sindhu’s last full-match win over the Japanese player had come at the Thailand Open in 2022.

The Indian made an aggressive start, racing to a 3-0 lead before Yamaguchi fought back to level at 3-3. Sindhu gradually regained control through accurate net play and well-planned attacks, moving ahead 9-6 before Yamaguchi edged in front at the mid-game interval.

The momentum shifted after the break when Sindhu won a demanding 36-shot rally to make it 11-11. She followed it with a series of attacking winners to build a 16-12 lead. Yamaguchi stayed in the contest and drew level at 17-17 after an intense 38-shot exchange, but Sindhu responded with two decisive points before closing out the opening game with a precise shot into her opponent’s backhand corner.

Sindhu carried that confidence into the second game, controlling the forecourt and taking the shuttle early to deny Yamaguchi time to settle. A physically demanding 44-shot rally ended in her favour as she won six consecutive points to move 8-3 ahead.

Although Yamaguchi reduced the deficit to 8-7, Sindhu restored control to lead 11-7 at the interval. The Indian extended her advantage to 14-7 as her opponent struggled with errors and failed on another video challenge.

Yamaguchi mounted one final comeback to cut the lead to 14-12 and later narrowed the gap to 19-17 after Sindhu twice found the net. But the Japanese player then sent a return wide before another error at the net handed Sindhu three championship points.

The Indian sealed the match when Yamaguchi’s final return landed long. The line call was confirmed after a video review, and Sindhu celebrated the landmark victory with an embrace of her coach as she completed a memorable run to her first Japan Open title.

BAC TOOK NOTE OF THE SUGGESTIONS

Speaker Birla appeals to all parties for smooth conduct of Monsoon Session

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A day before the Monsoon Session of Parliament commences, Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Sunday appealed to all parties to extend their full cooperation to ensure the smooth and orderly conduct of the proceedings so that issues concerning people can be discussed comprehensively and productively.

Chairing a meeting of the Business Advisory Committee (BAC), Birla also emphasised the importance of constructive deliberations, meaningful participation and adherence to the highest Parliamentary traditions.

The Speaker appealed to all parties to cooperate for a smooth and orderly session so that issues concerning people can be discussed in a comprehensive and productive manner, an official aware of the deliberations of the meeting said.

Birla also invited representatives from all political parties to the Lok Sabha to put forward their views on issues of public



Om Birla

interest.

At the meeting, members representing the government and the Opposition parties exchanged their views on the legislative and other businesses proposed to be taken up during the session.

The members also suggested several matters of public importance and national concern for discussion during the course of the session.

The BAC took note of the suggestions.

The scheduling of discussions and allocation of time for

Highlights

» Birla also invited representatives from all political parties to the Lok Sabha to put forward their views on issues of public interest

» Birla also emphasised the importance of constructive deliberations, meaningful participation

various items of business will be finalised in accordance with the established Parliamentary procedures and in consultation with the government and leaders of the Opposition parties, another official said.

The Speaker expressed confidence that all members would work collectively to ensure a productive and dignified Monsoon Session in the larger public interest.

After the meeting, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju said important Bills that have been submitted by the gov-

ernment have been allocated time.

“The Opposition has also made some suggestions, which we have noted. We have appealed to the Opposition that when Parliament meets tomorrow morning, there should be no turmoil. If the Opposition does not create turmoil, some Bills will be taken up for discussion tomorrow,” Rijiju said.

Some Bills are ready to be introduced, for which time has been allocated, the minister said.

“But if the Opposition creates turmoil, there will be little business,” Rijiju said, but refused to disclose which Bills will be taken up on the first day.

Deputy leader of Congress in Lok Sabha Gaurav Gogoi said the Opposition has clearly conveyed that it will offer constructive participation and support for the government's Bills, but in return, it expects the government to demonstrate its moral responsibility and provide answers on critical public issues.

Unfortunately, Gogoi said, he has not seen any indication

of preparation or a clear stance from the government on matters of public interest; “instead, the government is merely buying time”.

“Even today, people of the country do not know if the government is prepared to discuss the Ram Mandir issue, or NEET or the ethanol policy,” Gogoi said.

The Congress leader also claimed that the government has not offered any clarity on these specific issues so far.

“It seems the government is strategising to evade these topics entirely and trying to create an atmosphere in the House that stifles discussion and suppresses these issues,” he said.

Among others, the BAC meeting was attended by rebel Trinamool Congress (TMC) leader Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar.

On Sunday morning, the entire Opposition staged a symbolic walkout from an all-party meeting convened ahead of the Monsoon Session to protest against the invitation extended to rebel TMC MPs.

MP Cabinet clears UCC draft Bill, sets stage for Assembly test

Bill reflects constitutional principle of equality: CM

SATYAPRAKASH SHARMA

BHOPAL: Madhya Pradesh moved a step closer to enacting a Uniform Civil Code (UCC) after the Cabinet, chaired by Chief Minister Mohan Yadav, approved the draft Bill on Sunday. It will be introduced in the Monsoon Session of the Assembly beginning on Monday.

Addressing reporters after the special Cabinet meeting held at the Gond tribal fort in Jagdishpur on the outskirts of the state capital, Yadav described the proposed legislation as a significant step towards women's empowerment.

He said the law would ensure equal rights for Ram, Rahim, Ravinder and Robin. The Chief Minister said the proposed legislation aimed to guarantee equal rights for every citizen, irrespective of religion.

“Today, the Cabinet wholeheartedly and unanimously approved the Bill,” he said.

Yadav said the Bill reflects the constitutional principle of equality and is rooted in India's cultural values.

We have moved forward in this direction, ensuring the



Bill is ready to be tabled during the Monsoon session. For us, equality has always been an integral part of Indian culture and values, the CM said.

The CM claimed the proposed Bill had received overwhelming public support.

He said a seven-member committee was formed on April 27 to examine the issue, invite suggestions and study the implementation of the UCC in states where it is already enforced.

According to the CM, the committee received 9.58 lakh suggestions, while the government also gathered public opinions through rallies and the media.

He said nearly 3 crore SMSs were received during the consultation process.

He added that 93.54 per cent of respondents supported the implementation of the UCC in the state.

Highlighting responses from the Muslim community, Yadav said 80 per cent of women and 40 per cent of men of the community who participated in the consultation favoured a UCC.

The proposed Bill, which exempts Scheduled Tribes, including the Bhil, Gond, Korku, Baiga, Sahariya and Bhariya communities, covers marriage, live-in relationships, adoption and inheritance. It also outlaws verbal, unilateral and informal divorces, making them punishable offences.

Yadav said that the legislation provides for equal legal status for all children born through marriage, live-in relationships, adoption, surrogacy, and ART (assisted reproductive technology).

The marriageable age for men is 21, and for women 18, he said, adding that marriage registration is mandatory under the UCC.

Amit Shah to introduce Bill granting legal protection to ‘Vande Mataram’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Union Home minister Amit Shah is all set to introduce a Bill in the Rajya Sabha on Monday, providing legal protection to India's National Song “Vande Mataram”.

The Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026 has been placed on the agenda of the ongoing Monsoon Session of Parliament.

The amendment Bill seeks to give equal status to the National Song “Vande Mataram” as the National Anthem, the National Flag and the Constitution of India.

Once enacted, the amended law will make wilful insult and

deliberate disruption of singing of the National Song a punishable offence.

As per the draft of the Bill, the punishment for insulting “Vande Mataram” will be same as laid out for showing disrespect to the National Anthem, the National Flag and the Constitution.

The Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971 already provides for imprisonment for a term of up to three years, fine or both for wilfully prevents from singing of the National Anthem.

Likewise, the new law will also provide for imprisonment for a term of up to three years, fine or both for show-

ing disrespect to the National Song. Granting “Vande Mataram” the status of a National Song is a part of the government's efforts to propagate and popularise it. In addition, the government also aims to imbibe it in mainstream culture.

Recently, the government has made provisions to play/sing the National Song “Vande Mataram” alongside the National Anthem on special occasions.

The amendment Bill will be introduced by Amit Shah in the Rajya Sabha on Monday. Thereafter, it will be discussed in the Upper House before being taken up for consideration and passage in the Lok Sabha.

Rajya Sabha MPs incurred expenditure of Rs 262 cr in last 2 yrs: RTI

JAIPUR: More than Rs 262 crore was spent on salaries, allowances and facilities for all sitting Rajya Sabha MPs in the last two financial years 2024-25 and 2025-26, with over Rs 151 crore spent on their allowances and travel alone, an RTI reply has shown.

In 2024-25, the state exchequer spent over Rs 98 crore on Rajya Sabha members, which significantly increased to Rs 163 crore in 2025-26, a rise of Rs 65 crore. The amount includes domestic travel, international travel, office expenses and medical bills.

In 2024-25, salaries amounted to over Rs 25.71 crore, medical bills to Rs 8.2 crore, tour expenses to Rs 24.99 crore and allowances to the MPs to over Rs 33.33 crore. MPOST

Ram temple trust to meet on July 22

AYODHYA: Amid the ongoing Ram temple donation embezzlement row, the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust will hold a second meeting this month, on July 22.

According to Trust general secretary Krishna Mohan, a special meeting has been scheduled at 3 pm in the Ram temple complex, followed by the regular Trust meeting at 4 pm at Maniram Chawni, the premises of Trust president Nriya Gopal Das.

As per the agenda circulated by Krishna Mohan in a letter to the trustees on July 7, the July 22 meeting will take up confirmation of proceedings of the July 6 meeting as well as the special meeting at 3 pm the same day.

The trustees will also discuss the reconstitution of various committees in accordance with the

Trust's rules and deliberate on the final report of the Special Investigation Team (SIT) probing the donation theft, if it is available by then.

The July 6 meeting was the first Trust meeting after the alleged embezzlement of donations came to light.

During that meeting, the Trust constituted a special committee to recommend amendments to the Trust deed and framed guidelines for the custody, valuation and disposal of offerings made by devotees.

The meeting was initially scheduled to be held at Maniram Chawni but was later shifted to the Ram temple complex.

The proposed discussion on the SIT's final report assumes significance as the state government had ordered an inquiry into the embezzlement of donations received at the temple. MPOST

Derek seeks all-party meet over Delimitation, FCRA Bills

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: Trinamool Congress MP Derek O'Brien has written to Prime Minister Narendra Modi seeking an immediate all-party meeting to discuss the proposed Delimitation Bill and the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, ahead of the Monsoon Session of Parliament.

In his letter, O'Brien raised concerns over the possibility of the Delimitation Bill being introduced without prior notice.

He pointed out that no Delimitation Bill figures in the Parliamentary bulletin listing government business for the upcoming session, but said there was no guarantee that it would not be introduced suddenly.

Citing the 2019 Jammu and Kashmir Reorganisation Bill, O'Brien alleged that it was introduced in the Rajya Sabha 11 minutes before the Supplementary List of Business was circulated to MPs.

He urged the government to consult all political parties before pursuing what he described as a “cowboy” approach to law-making, referring to the Centre's subsequent withdrawal of the controversial farm laws.

“Delimitation concerns the very structure of India's polity and the future of our democracy,” O'Brien wrote. He also referred to the Delimitation Bill introduced in the Lok Sabha on April 16 along with the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill and legislation related to Union Territories. The Bill was rejected

on April 17 after failing to secure the required two-thirds majority.

Opposing the proposed FCRA Amendment Bill, O'Brien warned that its passage could affect institutions working in education, healthcare and social welfare, particularly those serving poor and marginalised communities. He cited around 54,000 educational institutions run by the Christian community, serving nearly six crore students annually.

He alleged that the proposed amendment could impose excessive control over charitable organisations, raising concerns under Articles 19 and 26 of the Constitution. O'Brien urged the Prime Minister to hold an all-party meeting before proceeding with the proposed legislations.

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JULY 2026

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- File your ITR on the e-filing portal (eportal.incometax.gov.in).
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* ITR-2: For Individuals and HUFs not having income from profits and gains of business or profession.



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SHIFT ACTIVIST ON FAST TO HOSPITAL

MP: Cops clear Ken Betwa project protest site on 17th day

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHHATARPUR: Police on Sunday broke up a 17-day protest against the Ken-Betwa Link and other development projects in Madhya Pradesh's Chhatarpur district by dispersing protesters and shifting movement leader Amit Bhatnagar, who has been on fast for 11 days, to hospital after his health "worsened".

Police justified the early morning action, citing a serious safety risk to the demonstrators from the rising level of the Barana river as the protest was being staged beneath an under-construction bridge and partly in the river.

Protesters alleged that Bhatnagar and others were detained during the police action, a claim denied by the administration.

The protest, mainly by tribal women, had been underway since July 3 on the banks of the Barana river near Kupi village. Protesters had also staged jal satyagraha, chita (funeral pyre) satyagraha and a symbolic faansi satyagraha.

The Ken-Betwa Link Project, the country's first river interlinking project under the National Perspective Plan, aims to transfer surplus water from the Ken to the Betwa river to provide irrigation and drinking water in the drought-prone Bundelkhand region of Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh.

The project has faced opposition from sections of project-affected families and environmental groups over issues relating to displacement, rehabilitation and its impact on forests and wildlife, including parts of the Panna Tiger Reserve.

One of the protesters, Divya Ahirwar, alleged that police



Security officials at the banks of the Barana river during the 15-day protest against the Ken-Betwa Link, in Chhatarpur district, Sunday

Key Points

- » The protest, mainly by tribal women, had been underway since July 3 on the banks of the Barana river near Kupi village
- » Protesters had also staged jal satyagraha, chita (funeral pyre) satyagraha and a symbolic faansi satyagraha

personnel reached the site in large numbers around 5 am and detained Bhatnagar and others before he could address the media regarding the alleged corruption of Rs 400 crore in the project.

She said the protesters had been demanding compliance with legal and constitutional provisions in implementing the project. "The administration would be responsible if any harm came to Bhatnagar or any of the protesters," Ahirwar added.

Additional Superintendent of Police Aditya Patle told news

agency that protesters were taken in buses to their native villages.

"Those from Panna district were sent there, while those from Chhatarpur and nearby areas were dropped at their respective villages," he added.

Patle denied that any protester had been arrested or detained.

He said Bhatnagar's health had deteriorated because of his prolonged hunger strike, and he was admitted to the hospital for medical treatment.

The officer said the protest site was beneath an under-construction bridge and partly in the Barana River, where rising water levels posed a serious safety risk.

He said the protesters, who were largely from neighbouring Panna district, should have staged their agitation there if their grievances were related to that district.

Meanwhile, the leader of the Opposition in the Madhya Pradesh Assembly, Umang Singhar, criticised the police action and expressed concern over Bhatnagar's hospitalisation.

NTA warns against fake & AI-generated OMR sheets, legal action may follow

NEET-UG

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The National Testing Agency (NTA) has issued an advisory to NEET-UG 2026 candidates and their parents, warning them not to submit fake or AI-generated OMR sheets when raising complaints about score discrepancies.

The warning comes after the NTA reviewed several complaints regarding differences between candidates' expected and declared NEET 2026 scores.

During the verification process, the agency found that many of the OMR sheets submitted with complaints appeared to be fake or created using artificial intelligence (AI).

"NTA is closely monitoring and scrutinising all complaints. In the wake of many

Closer Look

- » The warning comes after the NTA reviewed several complaints regarding differences between candidates' expected and declared NEET 2026 scores
- » The results for the

medical entrance were announced on July 16, with 11.21 lakh candidates qualifying the exam

- » The NTA cancelled the May 3 exam on May 12 amid allegations of a paper leak

OMR sheets submitted for scrutiny turning out to be fake/AI-generated, students and parents are advised to submit only original OMRs for scrutiny. Any fake/AI-generated OMR may invite legal action against the complainant," the agency said in an advisory.

The results for the medical entrance were announced on July 16, with 11.21 lakh candidates qualifying the exam.

'Paper leak issue turns epidemic in country'

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Former Chief Minister and Leader of the Opposition Bhupinder Singh Hooda stated that the problem of paper leaks has assumed the proportions of an epidemic across the country.

The Congress party, under the leadership of Rahul Gandhi, is spearheading a nationwide movement through the 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' (Voice of Students) campaign.

Hooda noted that 7.5 crore candidates have been affected so far due to the recurring paper leaks under the BJP government. This issue is not limited to competitive examinations alone as rampant paper leaks are occurring across various recruitment exams as well. The



unemployment situation is such that 9 crore youths apply for a mere 6 lakh jobs annually.

The Congress party is taking the 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' campaign across the nation to raise public awareness about this critical issue under the slogan 'Save Education, Save the Future,' the Congress. Addressing a press conference, Hooda remarked that Haryana has become a hub for paper leaks, and the employment situation in the state is even worse.

NEET RESULTS REVEALS A STORY OF FORTITUDE

Bundi student worked as whitewasher scores 99.16%

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Takeaways

- » Suraj, a resident of Kapren town in Bundi, cracked the National Eligibility Cum Entrance Test (NEET), scoring an impressive 99.16

percentile with 583 marks

- » Suraj said the image of his mother working hard daylong in the fields during his early years motivated him

college.

For Suraj, a student of Allen Career Institute in Kota, this achievement is far more than an academic milestone; it is a lifeline out of a difficult childhood marked by financial distress and the separation of his parents.

His story is one of relentless fortitude and the family's tireless strife to better their lives. Suraj lives with his mother Ghisi Bai, an agricul-

tural labourer, and younger sister Garima, who had to drop out of school due to the family's financial circumstances. His father lives separately.

Suraj studied up to Class 8 in a government school in Kapren. Following his parents' separation, he, along with his mother and sister, moved into his maternal grandparents' home at Alkodia village in Talera, where he enrolled for Class 9 in a local school.

Despite hardships, Suraj never let his academic focus slip; he scored 87 per cent marks in Class 10 and 85 per cent in Class 12. Inspired by his maternal aunt, who is an ANM nurse in Jodhpur's healthcare department, Suraj took up the Biology stream and aspired to become a doctor.

He spent his vacations and after-school hours working as a whitewasher, thus helping his mother keep the household afloat.

Due to the financial crunch, his younger sister Garima was forced to discontinue her education after Class 8 and join their mother in the fields.

Suraj said the image of his mother working hard daylong in the fields during his early years motivated him.

Nation Briefs

CBI CONDUCTS SEARCHES IN 1,109 CR CANARA BANK FRAUD CASE

NEW DELHI: CBI has conducted searches at six places in four states in connection with a Rs 1,109-crore fraud case involving Canara Bank. The searches were concluded on July 18 in Odisha, West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, and Uttarakhand after search warrants were issued by the Special CBI Court in Bhubaneswar. The CBI chargesheet stated that the alleged fraud was committed by misappropriating and diverting the fund-based and non-fund-based credit facilities availed by Gupta Power Infrastructure Ltd, Bhubaneswar from Canara Bank. Besides, the accused had also inflated the values of shares, gross trade receivables, and falsified the books of accounts to avail of higher limits of credit. It was also alleged that they manipulated the accounts of the company to perpetrate evergreening of loans to the tune of Rs 1,109 crore resulting in loss to Canara Bank.

TN: MAN HACKS SISTER TO DEATH, INJURES BROTHER-IN-LAW OVER LAND DISPUTE

KALLAKURICHI: A long-standing family property dispute turned violent when a man allegedly hacked his sister to death and severely injured his brother-in-law at their residence in the Sankarapuram area of this district. The incident took place on Saturday night. The deceased was identified as Deepa, a government hospital. According to police, Deepa and her brother, Kanthakumar, had been embroiled in a bitter feud for the past two years over a 30-cent plot of land.

Himachal plans ODTP mega event to rejuvenate rural economy

ASHWANI SHARMA

SHIMLA: In an initiative that will mark a new turning point in giving a targeted boost to the state's rural economy, the Himachal Pradesh government has decided to go beyond the conventional industrial promotion goals to pitch for "one district, three products" for the global market.

"The idea of unlocking the state's potential to be a commercial hub for village-based indigenous projects, which is expected to change the fortunes of the craftspeople and rural artisans, some of them known for their high-grade products," said Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu.

Under this plan, three signature products (based on uniqueness & market potential) from each district will be strengthened.

This will involve value chain analysis followed by forward integration, which will entail smarter branding and packaging, enhancing national and international market access, thereby promising higher returns for local manufacturers.

Sukhu says, "Our government's vision of making Himachal Pradesh self-reliant will be realised through this rural-centric initiative. It will play a significant role in revitalising the state's rural economy. The initiative will be supported through the upcoming new industrial policy."

Rolling out the plan of the industries department minister for industries, Harshwardhan Chauhan, said the government is planning a mega event in October 2026 to boost recognition and market linkages for district projects (ODTPs), district Products.

Under the initiative, 36 products, three from each district, have been identified following a comprehensive assessment of their economic potential, market demand, and local significance.

National Badminton Championship: CM reviews preparedness in Jalandhar

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Sunday reviewed the preparedness for the Sub-Junior National Badminton Championship scheduled to be held at the historic Raizada Hansraj Stadium in Jalandhar in December this year.

During his visit, the Chief Minister announced a special grant of Rs 2.14 crore for the construction of a state-of-the-art indoor badminton hall, reaffirming the Punjab government's commitment to strengthening sports infrastructure and promoting sporting excellence across the state.

During this, CM Mann said that after nearly 44 years, the

Chief Minister handed over the sanction cheque of Rs 2.14 crore for construction of new indoor badminton hall

National Badminton Championship is returning to the historic Raizada Hansraj Stadium.

"The championship will provide a major boost to badminton in Punjab and further strengthen the sporting culture in the state. The Punjab government is committed to promoting sports to channelise the boundless energy of the youth in a

positive direction," he added. The Chief Minister handed over the sanction cheque of Rs 2.14 crore to Deputy Commissioner (DC) Jalandhar Varjeet Singh Walia and Secretary of the Punjab Badminton Association Ritin Khanna for the construction of the new indoor badminton hall.

"It is the first time in nearly six decades that a sitting Chief Minister has visited this iconic stadium, which has produced several outstanding badminton players," he noted.

Meanwhile, CM Mann on Sunday paid obeisance at the Darbar of Dera Almast Babu Lal Badshah Ji during the annual fair at Nakodar and sought blessings for the peace, prosperity and all-round development of Punjab.

Study: Asia largest marble waste dumping yard in Rajasthan's Kishangarh – a pollution hotspot

The research has been conducted by researchers at Central University of Rajasthan

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Asia's largest marble waste dumping yard in Rajasthan's Kishangarh, which has become a popular tourist destination, is a pollution hotspot with PM 2.5 concentrations 4-12 times higher than CPCB limits and 20-50 times higher than WHO recommendations, a new research has found.

The research, which is the first study documenting the hazardous effects of the pristine looking dumpyard, has been conducted by researchers at Central University of Rajasthan.

The study titled "Industrial pollution to environmental degradation and human health: Evidence from the marble industries in Kishangarh, India" has been published in the prestigious "Journal of Hazardous Materials Advances".

According to Laxmi Kant Sharma, Environmental Science professor at Central University of Rajasthan, who led the research, this is the first



Highlights

- » The findings suggest that marble dust exposure may be associated with environmental degradation and self-reported health symptoms
- » The study found that the pollution findings are consistent with the high prevalence of skin disease and respiratory problems reported in the health survey

study conducted in a 15 km buffer around the marble waste dumping yard to assess irrigated and rain-fed agricultural soil, groundwater, and air quality, evaluate pollutant concentration by using Atomic Absorption Spectroscopy (AAS), and determine the mineralogical signature of contamination by X-ray

diffraction (XRD) analysis.

The findings suggest that marble dust exposure may be associated with environmental degradation and self-reported health symptoms, underscoring the importance of environmental monitoring, regulatory oversight, and public health interventions.

mp
EDITORIAL
TEST OF
ACCOUNTABILITY

The Monsoon Session of Parliament begins under a familiar cloud of confrontation, but this time the political arithmetic has changed even before the first slogan is raised. The Opposition enters the session determined to corner the government over paper leaks, Sonam Wangchuk's detention after his prolonged hunger strike, the alleged theft of donations at the Ram Temple, ethanol blending policy and foreign affairs. Yet its own cohesion appears increasingly fragile. The shifting of more than three dozen Opposition MPs to the NDA has strengthened the government numerically while exposing ideological and strategic fault lines within the Opposition. The walkout from the all-party meeting over the recognition of rebel factions only underlined this disunity. Parliament functions best when a strong government is matched by an equally coherent Opposition. Today, one appears more confident while the other struggles to project a united front. That imbalance risks reducing serious national debates into fragmented political skirmishes.

For the government, however, numbers alone cannot substitute for accountability. The issues likely to dominate the session touch citizens directly. The recurring examination paper leaks have shaken public faith in merit-based recruitment and education. Wangchuk's removal from his protest site has revived questions about democratic dissent and the state's tolerance of peaceful agitation. Allegations surrounding the finances of the Ram Temple Trust demand transparency precisely because the institution carries immense religious and emotional significance. These are not merely Opposition talking points but matters that deserve credible responses from the executive. The government's caution over introducing contentious legislation, including the proposed delimitation reforms and other constitutional amendments, suggests an awareness that legislative success depends not only on parliamentary strength but also on public legitimacy. A comfortable majority can pass laws, but it cannot erase doubts if legitimate concerns remain unanswered.

The coming weeks will therefore test more than political numbers; they will test the quality of India's parliamentary democracy. The government should resist the temptation to rely solely on its strengthened position and instead engage substantively with difficult questions. Equally, the Opposition must recognise that disruption without strategic unity rarely translates into effective accountability. Parliament is not merely a battleground for political optics but the principal institution through which competing visions of governance are debated and scrutinised. With the economy facing global uncertainties and several major policy decisions awaiting legislative attention, the country can ill afford another session consumed entirely by procedural chaos and partisan acrimony. Robust debate, transparency and constructive engagement remain the true measures of parliamentary success. The Monsoon Session offers both sides an opportunity to demonstrate that democratic institutions are strongest not when one side overwhelms the other, but when government and Opposition alike fulfil their constitutional responsibilities with seriousness and restraint.

TALKING SHOP



RAJEEV NARAYAN

THE WRITER IS A VETERAN JOURNALIST AND COMMUNICATIONS SPECIALIST

The world's economic wave is ebbing and flowing to the rhythm of headlines emerging from West Asia. It is difficult to recount another conflict in recent history where peace has ended up becoming so relentlessly provisional

GREEN THOUGHTS



SUDHEER KUMAR SHUKLA

THE WRITER IS A DISTINGUISHED ENVIRONMENTAL SCIENTIST, SUSTAINABILITY EXPERT, AND POLICY ADVISOR

India's coastline stretches over 7,500 kilometres, yet warming waters, marine heatwaves, declining fish stocks and coastal pollution are exposing growing ecological and economic vulnerabilities

Off Today, On Tomorrow

Every ceasefire that flops, every missile that flies thereafter and every market that recoils soon after imposes an invisible tax on India. That tax is uncertainty

"Plans are worthless, but planning is everything."
— Dwight D Eisenhower

There is something theatrical, downright comical, about the way the West Asia conflict is unfolding. Figure this: United States President Donald Trump steps up to the podium to announce yet another breakthrough. Cameras flash. Diplomats applaud. The world is told peace has prevailed, shipping lanes will reopen, energy markets will stabilise and global inflation will begin to retreat. Oil prices soften, equity markets rally and investors briefly rediscover their appetite for risk.

Then comes the sequel: Another strike happens. Another retaliation. Another warning from Washington. Another military response from Tehran or its regional allies. Another scramble by traders to price risk into crude oil, freight and insurance. The applause fades. Markets recoil. Governments reopen contingency files that had just been returned to the filing cabinet.

And the reality: The latest collapse of the much-publicised ceasefire and renewed military standoff around the Strait of Hormuz have become just another reminder that in West Asia today, peace has acquired a shorter shelf-life than the speeches celebrating it. This is no longer a geopolitical story. It is an economic one. More importantly, it is an Indian economic elegiac. **Unfinished War**

Wars have always imposed costs. But wars that repeatedly pause, restart and refuse to conclude enforce a different, greater burden. They replace certainty with speculation. They make planning impossible. They force businesses, governments and investors to prepare simulta-

neously for peace and conflict. The biggest casualty is no longer infrastructure. It is predictability. The distinction matters.

A conventional conflict eventually produces a new equilibrium. Markets adjust. Supply chains reorganise. Governments recalibrate policies. Investors learn to price in the new reality. On-off uncertainty offers no such luxury. Every diplomatic breakthrough becomes provisional. Every ceasefire is treated as temporary. Every reassuring headline carries a watermarked footnote: 'Subject to change without notice.'

For the global economy, uncertainty itself has become a commodity whose price is measured not in dollars but in delayed funding, postponed contracts, disrupted shipping schedules and rising insurance premiums.

Given this backdrop, India's exposure to these events and their implications is especially profound. It imports over 85 per cent of its crude oil needs. A lion's share of this originates in or transits through the world's most strategically-sensitive region. The Strait of Hormuz alone carries one-fifth of global oil and an equally critical share of liquefied natural gas. Every military escalation in these waters travels beyond the battlefield. It reaches Indian fuel pumps, factory floors, airline balance sheets and household budgets.

Beyond Crude Oil

The challenge is no longer confined to the price of oil. Freight rates become volatile. War-risk insurance premiums rise. Airlines struggle to hedge aviation turbine fuel. Importers hesitate over inventory decisions. Exporters find it harder to commit to long-term contracts. Investors reassess risk. The Reserve Bank of India remains vigilant



The world does not need another televised peace accord that unravels before the applause has faded

against imported inflation even when domestic demand remains stable. Policymakers who should be planning five years ahead huddle together in crisis-management mode.

The irony is naked and ugly. Especially as India itself is not a combatant. But every missile fired thousands of kilometres away rewrites assumptions inside North Block, Dalal Street and corporate boardrooms. The war has not crossed into India's borders. But its uncertainty has.

In times of war, global attention invariably gravitates towards missiles, military manoeuvres and diplomatic brinksmanship. Yet, the deeper economic damage occurs far from the battlefield – inside boardrooms, ministries and central banks. The cost of a stop-start conflict lies not only in disrupted oil supplies, but in hiccupping decision-making. For businesses can absorb high oil prices if they believe those prices will persist. They can recalibrate supply chains if they know trade routes have changed. Markets, after all, have always adapted to adversity. What businesses struggle to cope with is uncertainty.

Trade Pays the Price

The posers are myriad: Should shipping companies com-

mit additional vessels to the Gulf or reroute them around Africa? Should airlines hedge aviation turbine fuel today or wait another week? Should exporters lock-up six-month contracts, especially when freight charges could spike overnight? Should manufacturers build inventories or conserve working capital? Every unanswered question carries a huge monetary cost.

The International Monetary Fund has cautioned that geo-economic fragmentation and policy uncertainty threaten trade, investment and long-term growth. For economies seeking to remain engaged with multiple geopolitical blocs, uncertainty itself becomes an economic headwind. India is not immune to this.

Disruption to shipping through the Strait of Hormuz has already contributed to wider trade imbalances and heightened logistics uncertainty. Even where physical supplies remain uninterrupted, the dire possibility of disruption influences freight rates, insurance premiums and commercial planning. That is 'Uncertainty Tax'. It is invisible in government budgets, yet every business has to pay it. Plan for it.

India's Response

There is a cushion. India enters the uncertainty *chakravyyuh* from a position of relative strength, rather than vulnerability. Successive governments have diversified crude oil sourcing, expanded strategic petroleum reserves, accelerated renewable-energy capacity and invested in logistics, ports and related infrastructure. Strategic autonomy has enabled India to somewhat maintain constructive engagement across competing geopolitical camps, ensuring that diplomacy continues to serve economic interests.

These efforts matter. Because India's economic ambitions remain sky-high. The country aims to be declared a 'Developed Economy' by 2047, needing to sustain the fastest GDP growth rate, ever. That aspiration demands not just resilience against external shocks but the ability to continue investing, manufacturing and trading even when the global environment becomes unpredictable.

The RBI has identified geopolitical tensions as a risk that entices inflation and macroeconomic stability. It has pointed to developments in West Asia, alongside monsoon vagaries, as risks needing policy attention. The IMF's assessment echoes similar concerns. While praising India's macroeconomic fundamentals, it warns that deeper geo-economic fragmentation could weaken trade, investment and capital flows. That is why contingency planning can no longer remain a temporary exercise. It has to be permanent policy.

Beyond Ceasefires

The world does not need another televised peace accord that unravels before the applause has faded. It needs durable diplomacy. Headline-grabbing statements may calm markets for a

bit, but true confidence can only be built through credible institutions, predictable policy and partnerships that survive news cycles.

For India, the implications are clear. Energy diversification must continue with urgency. Strategic petroleum reserves need strengthening. Renewable energy, green hydrogen and domestic exploration must move from being climate initiatives to pillars of national economic security. Trade corridors should be diversified, logistics more resilient and supply chains less dependent on any single geopolitical chokepoint.

Businesses too have to rethink the architecture of risk. The chant that geopolitical crises are temporary interruptions is becoming obsolete. Uncertainty has become a permanent feature of global commerce. There was a time when economists treated war as an exception and peace as the baseline. West Asia has turned that assumption on its head. Today, peace resembles an intermission, not a happily-ever-after curtain-downer. That is the tragedy confronting the global economy.

For India, whose growth depends on stable energy supplies, steady exports, predictable investment and disciplined inflation, this is the defining economic challenge of the coming decade. History will eventually record who won or lost. But markets will remember something else – that an era of stop-start conflict transformed uncertainty into the Planet's most expensive commodity. That is the legacy of this on-off war. And that is the 'Uncertainty Tax' that India and the rest of the world can no longer afford to keep paying.

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The Ocean Can't Wait

The world's oceans sustain life, regulate climate and feed billions, yet accelerating degradation demands urgent action beyond declarations, diplomacy and delay

The ocean is Earth's largest ecosystem, its primary climate regulator, and a lifeline for over 3 billion people. It provides more than 50% of the oxygen we breathe, absorbs about 30% of CO₂ emissions, and moderates global temperatures. But as 2026 unfolds, this vast blue expanse is sending a clear message: it can no longer sustain the burden of our excesses, our heat, our waste, and our neglect.

Heat, Acid, and Hypoxia: The Triple Threat

Since the 1970s, the ocean has absorbed more than 90% of the excess heat generated by anthropogenic greenhouse gas emissions. In 2024 alone, the upper 2,000 meters of ocean water stored 16 zettajoules of energy about 140 times the world's annual electricity consumption. May 2025 witnessed the second-warmest sea surface temperatures on record, with marine heatwaves disrupting ecosystems from the Indian Ocean to the Mediterranean.

Warmer oceans not only fuel cyclones and alter weather patterns, but also reduce oxygen solubility. The number and size of 'dead zones' regions too oxygen-depleted to support marine life—have increased sharply, now affecting more than 500 coastal areas globally. Ocean acidification, the 'evil twin' of climate change, has intensified due to increased CO₂ absorption. Coastal waters in some regions now record pH levels below 7.9, threatening coral reefs, plankton, and shell-building organisms, the very base of the marine food chain.

Mass Coral Bleaching and Biodiversity Collapse

We have just lived through the most widespread global coral bleaching event in history. Bleaching-level heat struck reefs across more than 80 countries and territories between 2023 and 2025, affecting over 84% of the world's reef area, before NOAA scientists confirmed in mid-2026 that the event had likely run its course. The Great Barrier Reef, Australia's Ningaloo, and reefs across

the Maldives, the Caribbean, and Lakshadweep all suffered mass mortality. Live coral cover has decreased by over 50% since the 1870s, and scientists now warn that reefs are entering an era of near-annual bleaching, leaving ever-shorter windows for recovery. These losses are not only ecological but economic, as coral reefs contribute to fisheries, tourism, and coastal protection.

Plastic Oceans and Polluted Bloodstreams

The ocean has become a dumping ground for humanity's plastic addiction. Between 75 and 199 million tonnes of plastic waste are now floating in marine ecosystems. Every year, about 11 million tonnes of plastic enter the ocean—equivalent to two garbage trucks per minute. Microplastics have been detected in over 60% of fish species and 92% of global tap water samples. Alarming, they've now been found in human blood, lungs, and placentas.

While development banks have pledged over \$3.48 billion to curb marine plastic pollution, implementation lags behind. Worse, the legally binding international plastics treaty under the UN Environment Assembly (UNEA) that was meant to be finalised back in 2024 has now failed twice, first in Busan in December 2024, then in Geneva in August 2025, leaving the full plastic lifecycle of production, usage, disposal, and recycling unregulated. A new committee chair took over in February 2026 to attempt a reset, but substantive negotiations are not expected to resume until late 2026 or early 2027.

Overfishing, Inequity, and Food Insecurity

Overfishing, inequity, and food insecurity are deeply intertwined challenges facing the world's oceans today. According to the FAO, 35% of global fish stocks are overexploited, up from just 10% in the 1970s, driven largely by industrial fishing operations, many of which are heavily subsidised by developed nations. These industrial fleets often extract unsustainable yields from the waters of poorer countries, exacerbating inequality and



The ocean's crisis is no longer beneath the surface. It has become the defining environmental emergency of our time

depriving local communities of vital resources. Illegal, unreported, and unregulated (IUU) fishing further undermines marine sustainability, accounting for an estimated \$23 billion in lost marine resources annually. Trawlers, in particular, pose serious ecological threats by dragging massive nets across the seafloor, churning up carbon-rich sediments and releasing stored CO₂, thereby contributing to climate change. Disturbingly, about three-quarters of their catch is discarded as bycatch, leading to immense waste and biodiversity loss.

Industrial fishing vessels relentlessly hunt in every corner of the sea, including the fragile ecosystems of Antarctica, where krill, a keystone species, is now under threat. Meanwhile, several studies have reported that two-thirds of large predatory fish have already been lost, and the collapse of marine ecosystems looms ever closer. This crisis has grave consequences for the 3 billion people who rely on the ocean for food, especially in the Global South, where fish is a primary source of protein. Women—who make up over half of the fisheries workforce, often in informal, low-paid roles—are disproportionately affected. As climate shocks and resource depletion mount, so too does the gendered burden of economic and ecological collapse.

The Governance Gap: High Seas, Low Accountability

Despite the designation of thousands of Marine Protected Areas (MPAs), only about 10% of ocean territory is now formally protected up from 8.34% a year

ago, yet barely 3% is protected rigorously enough to deliver real conservation benefits, with much of the rest existing largely on paper. The 30x30 target (to conserve 30% of the ocean by 2030) remains achievable but demands urgent action, a message reiterated at the Our Ocean Conference held in Kenya this June. Meanwhile, the High Seas—covering nearly two-thirds of the global ocean and lying beyond national jurisdiction—have long been exposed to unregulated deep-sea mining, bioprospecting, and overfishing.

Here, 2025 delivered one genuine breakthrough. Momentum from the UN Ocean Conference in Nice carried the High Seas Treaty (the BBNJ Agreement) past the 60-ratification threshold in September 2025, and the treaty officially entered into force on 17 January 2026; more than 80 countries have now ratified it, out of 145 signatories. For the first time, areas beyond national jurisdiction have a binding legal framework for conservation. But entry into force is only the starting gun: the treaty's real effectiveness now depends on universal ratification, the rollout of high seas marine protected areas, and enforcement mechanisms that have yet to be tested.

While nearly \$10 billion was pledged for ocean-related finance at that conference, this still falls far short of the estimated \$175 billion required annually to achieve Sustainable Development Goal 14 (Life Below Water), and private sector contributions remain minimal. On deep-sea

mining, the precautionary camp has grown to 40 countries supporting a moratorium or pause, and in March 2026 the International Seabed Authority's Council once again ended its session without approving any mining or adopting a Mining Code, citing unresolved environmental and liability concerns. Nevertheless, exploration contracts continue, and global regulatory frameworks remain incomplete, reinforcing calls for a precautionary approach.

To secure meaningful progress, the following actions are essential:

- Build on the High Seas Treaty's entry into force by pushing for universal ratification and rigorous implementation.
- Mobilise large-scale, long-term ocean financing to close the funding gap.
- Finalise effective governance and enforcement mechanisms.
- Promote precautionary and sustainable use of marine resources.

India at the Oceanic Crossroads

With a 7,500-kilometre coastline, 200+ coastal cities, and a growing blue economy, India is both highly vulnerable and uniquely positioned to lead. The Bay of Bengal, one of the fastest-warming ocean regions, is already experiencing marine heatwaves, coral degradation, and declining fish yields. Programs such as the Deep Ocean Mission and Swachh Sagar, Surakshit Sagar are commendable starts. But to lead meaningfully, India must:

- Integrate ocean conservation into national climate and development strategies;
- Strengthen enforcement of coastal zone regulations and reduce land-based marine pollution;
- Expand MPAs with local community involvement and indigenous knowledge systems;
- Invest in blue carbon ecosystems—mangroves, seagrass beds, salt marshes;
- Foster ocean literacy and gender-responsive marine governance.

India's Ocean Health Index (OHI) score has continued to

slide, now standing at 57 out of 100 against a global average in the high 60s, with India ranked 207th out of 220 nations—down from 195th in 2023. This calls for urgent course correction in both policy and practice.

Charting a Blue Recovery: 6 Policy Imperatives

- **Push the High Seas Treaty Toward Universal Ratification** – The treaty is now in force; the next test is full ratification, MPA designation, and enforcement.
- **Finally Deliver a Global Plastics Treaty** – After two failed negotiating rounds, the 2026 reset must finally tackle plastic across its entire life cycle.
- **Expand and Fund MPAs** – Reach the 30x30 target with real surveillance, not just symbolic maps.
- **Mobilise Blue Finance** – Issue sovereign blue bonds and catalyse investments in ocean restoration.
- **Mainstream Ocean Literacy** – Embed Ocean education into school curricula and public discourse.
- **Harness AI and Satellite Tools** – For better ocean monitoring, early warning, and illegal activity tracking.

The Final Warning

The UN Decade of Ocean Science (2021–2030) is now more than halfway through, and progress remains sluggish. 2025 proved that multilateral action on the ocean is still possible—the High Seas Treaty's entry into force in January 2026 is real proof of that. But it also showed how easily momentum stalls: two more rounds of plastics treaty talks collapsed, and global ocean finance remains a fraction of what is needed. The ocean is not an infinite absorber of harm—it is a fragile, living system in collapse. We cannot afford to treat the ocean as out of sight, out of mind. Its crisis is not underwater—it is underacknowledged. Let 2026 be the year we build on the one promise that was kept, and finally deliver on the rest—trading complacency for commitment, and letting restoration replace rhetoric.

Views expressed are personal

US strikes Iran over attack that killed troops in Jordan

AGENCIES

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क्रमांक/निर्माण/2026-27/13२४६

निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना

भोपाल, दिनांक 15/7/२६

जनजातीय कार्य विभाग की ओर से ऑनलाइन निविदा प्रतियोगिता दर पर लोक निर्माण में उन्नति श्रेणी में पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों से भवन निर्माण विद्युतीकरण सहित लोक निर्माण विभाग (भवन) म.प्र. भोपाल द्वारा जारी दिनांक 01 जनवरी 2024 से प्रभावी तथो राह एवं ब्रिज निर्माण कार्य लोक निर्माण विभाग के प्रचलित एंव.ओ.आर. 11 अप्रैल 2025 से प्रावधानशील पर (निविदा दिकान तक संशोधन सहित) निम्नांकित कार्यों हेतु ऑनलाइन निविदा निम्न विवरण अनुसार आमंत्रित की जाती है। कार्यों का विवरण निम्नानुसार है:

क्र.	सिरमूण टेंडर नंबर.	खिला	कार्य का नाम	ठेके की अनुमानित लागत (राशि लाख मे)	अमानित राशि (रु. में.)	निविदा प्रपत्र रु. में	निविदा /कार्य पूर्णता अवधि	ठेकेदार की स्त्री
1	2026_TAD_521627_1	छिंदवाड़ा	या. हाई स्कूल, कालकुली, बि.छ. तामिया का नवीन भवन निर्माण मय विद्युतीकरण सहित	299.90	299900/-	15000/-	18 माह वर्षा ऋतु सहित	लो.मि.वि. में नवीन केंद्रीकृत पद्धति में सिलिब कार्य हेतु जीएलटी पीसीडी
2	2026_TAD_521628_1	छिंदवाड़ा	या. हाई स्कूल, जमुनीया, बि.छ. तामिया का नवीन भवन निर्माण मय विद्युतीकरण सहित	299.90	299900/-	15000/-	18 माह वर्षा ऋतु सहित	लो.मि.वि. में नवीन केंद्रीकृत पद्धति में सिलिब कार्य हेतु जीएलटी पीसीडी
3	2026_TAD_521629_1	छिंदवाड़ा	या. हाई स्कूल, खिरदी, बि.छ. तामिया का नवीन भवन निर्माण मय विद्युतीकरण सहित	299.90	299900/-	15000/-	18 माह वर्षा ऋतु सहित	लो.मि.वि. में नवीन केंद्रीकृत पद्धति में सिलिब कार्य हेतु जीएलटी पीसीडी
4	2026_TAD_521631_1	छिंदवाड़ा	या. हाई स्कूल, सिंचौली, बि.छ. तामिया का नवीन भवन निर्माण मय विद्युतीकरण सहित	299.90	299900/-	15000/-	18 माह वर्षा ऋतु सहित	लो.मि.वि. में नवीन केंद्रीकृत पद्धति में सिलिब कार्य हेतु जीएलटी पीसीडी
5	2026_TAD_521632_1	छिंदवाड़ा	या. हाई स्कूल, गनुस्करपुर, बि.छ. तामिया का नवीन भवन निर्माण मय विद्युतीकरण सहित	299.90	299900/-	15000/-	18 माह वर्षा ऋतु सहित	लो.मि.वि. में नवीन केंद्रीकृत पद्धति में सिलिब कार्य हेतु जीएलटी पीसीडी
6	2026_TAD_521635_1	छिंदवाड़ा	या. हाई स्कूल, महाई, बि.छ. हरेई का नवीन भवन निर्माण मय विद्युतीकरण सहित	299.90	299900/-	15000/-	18 माह वर्षा ऋतु सहित	लो.मि.वि. में नवीन केंद्रीकृत पद्धति में सिलिब कार्य हेतु जीएलटी पीसीडी
7	2026_TAD_521636_1	छिंदवाड़ा	या. हाई स्कूल, अगौराय, बि.छ. हरेई का नवीन भवन निर्माण मय विद्युतीकरण सहित	299.90	299900/-	15000/-	18 माह वर्षा ऋतु सहित	लो.मि.वि. में नवीन केंद्रीकृत पद्धति में सिलिब कार्य हेतु जीएलटी पीसीडी
8	2026_TAD_521637_1	छिंदवाड़ा	या. हाई स्कूल, कटकुली, बि.छ. जुमुरदेई का नवीन भवन निर्माण मय विद्युतीकरण सहित	299.90	299900/-	15000/-	18 माह वर्षा ऋतु सहित	लो.मि.वि. में नवीन केंद्रीकृत पद्धति में सिलिब कार्य हेतु जीएलटी पीसीडी
9	2026_TAD_521638_1	छिंदवाड़ा	या. हाई स्कूल, जंबावेरवार, बि.छ. जुमुरदेई का नवीन भवन निर्माण मय विद्युतीकरण सहित	299.90	299900/-	15000/-	18 माह वर्षा ऋतु सहित	लो.मि.वि. में नवीन केंद्रीकृत पद्धति में सिलिब कार्य हेतु जीएलटी पीसीडी
10	2026_TAD_521639_1	छिंदवाड़ा	या. हाई स्कूल, सोनाखेडा, बि.छ. जुमुरदेई का नवीन भवन निर्माण मय विद्युतीकरण सहित	299.90	299900/-	15000/-	18 माह वर्षा ऋतु सहित	लो.मि.वि. में नवीन केंद्रीकृत पद्धति में सिलिब कार्य हेतु जीएलटी पीसीडी
11	2026_TAD_521640_1	छिंदवाड़ा	या. हाई स्कूल, मिनागाँगी, बि.छ. मिष्ठुआ का नवीन भवन निर्माण मय विद्युतीकरण सहित	299.90	299900/-	15000/-	18 माह वर्षा ऋतु सहित	लो.मि.वि. में नवीन केंद्रीकृत पद्धति में सिलिब कार्य हेतु जीएलटी पीसीडी
12	2026_TAD_521641_1	छिंदवाड़ा	या. हाई स्कूल, पोढामाल, बि.छ. मिष्ठुआ का नवीन भवन निर्माण मय विद्युतीकरण सहित	299.90	299900/-	15000/-	18 माह वर्षा ऋतु सहित	लो.मि.वि. में नवीन केंद्रीकृत पद्धति में सिलिब कार्य हेतु जीएलटी पीसीडी
13	2026_TAD_521642_1	छिंदवाड़ा	या. हाई स्कूल, लोहांगी, बि.छ. मिष्ठुआ का नवीन भवन निर्माण मय विद्युतीकरण सहित	299.90	299900/-	15000/-	18 माह वर्षा ऋतु सहित	लो.मि.वि. में नवीन केंद्रीकृत पद्धति में सिलिब कार्य हेतु जीएलटी पीसीडी
14	2026_TAD_521643_1	छिंदवाड़ा	या. हाई स्कूल, डवानिया, बि.छ. जुमुरदेई का नवीन भवन निर्माण मय विद्युतीकरण सहित	299.90	299900/-	15000/-	18 माह वर्षा ऋतु सहित	लो.मि.वि. में नवीन केंद्रीकृत पद्धति में सिलिब कार्य हेतु जीएलटी पीसीडी
15	2026_TAD_521644_1	छिंदवाड़ा	या. हाई स्कूल, बदोसा, बि.छ. मिष्ठुआ का नवीन भवन निर्माण मय विद्युतीकरण सहित	299.90	299900/-	15000/-	18 माह वर्षा ऋतु सहित	लो.मि.वि. में नवीन केंद्रीकृत पद्धति में सिलिब कार्य हेतु जीएलटी पीसीडी
16	2026_TAD_521646_1	छिंदवाड़ा	या. हाई स्कूल, खमरियावाला, बि.छ. मिष्ठुआ का नवीन भवन निर्माण मय विद्युतीकरण सहित	299.90	299900/-	15000/-	18 माह वर्षा ऋतु सहित	लो.मि.वि. में नवीन केंद्रीकृत पद्धति में सिलिब कार्य हेतु जीएलटी पीसीडी
17	2026_TAD_521647_1	छिंदवाड़ा	या. हाई स्कूल, बावरी, बि.छ. जुमुरदेई का नवीन भवन निर्माण मय विद्युतीकरण सहित	299.90	299900/-	15000/-	18 माह वर्षा ऋतु सहित	लो.मि.वि. में नवीन केंद्रीकृत पद्धति में सिलिब कार्य हेतु जीएलटी पीसीडी
18	2026_TAD_521649_1	छिंदवाड़ा	या. हाई स्कूल, डाठाबाबा, बि.छ. हरेई का नवीन भवन निर्माण मय विद्युतीकरण सहित	299.90	299900/-	15000/-	18 माह वर्षा ऋतु सहित	लो.मि.वि. में नवीन केंद्रीकृत पद्धति में सिलिब कार्य हेतु जीएलटी पीसीडी
19	2026_TAD_521650_1	छिंदवाड़ा	या. हाई स्कूल, देवरी, बि.छ. मिष्ठुआ का नवीन भवन निर्माण मय विद्युतीकरण सहित	299.90	299900/-	15000/-	18 माह वर्षा ऋतु सहित	लो.मि.वि. में नवीन केंद्रीकृत पद्धति में सिलिब कार्य हेतु जीएलटी पीसीडी
20	2026_TAD_521651_1	छिंदवाड़ा	या. हाई स्कूल, फोराड़, बि.छ. मिष्ठुआ का नवीन भवन निर्माण मय विद्युतीकरण सहित	299.90	299900/-	15000/-	18 माह वर्षा ऋतु सहित	लो.मि.वि. में नवीन केंद्रीकृत पद्धति में सिलिब कार्य हेतु जीएलटी पीसीडी

- इच्छुक निविदाकार MP Tenders के पोर्टल पर विवरण देख सकते हैं।
- NIT (निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना) में किसी प्रकार के परिवर्तन सूचना केवल www.mptenders.gov.in पर प्रकाशित की जाएगी।
- निविदा प्रपत्र की उपलब्धता का विस्तृत विवरण : www.mptenders.gov.in पर देखा जा सकता है।
- प्रस्ताव प्रमा करने की प्रक्रिया केवल उपरोक्त पोर्टल पर ऑनलाइन माध्यम से की जाएगी।
- संशोधन/परिशिष्ट/स्पष्टीकरण/ सुद्धि पत्रक केवल www.mptenders.gov.in पर प्रकाशित किए जाएंगे।
- आयुक्त, जनजातीय कार्य विभाग को बिना कोई कारण बताए किसी भी या सभी निविदाओं को अस्वीकार करने का अधिकार सुरक्षित है।

G1591/26

“रचना स्वच्छता, संस्कार स्वच्छता”

अधीक्षक यंत्री
जनजातीय कार्य
भोपाल, म.प्र.

MONSOON SESSION

I-T, MSME Bills among key economic legislations listed

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The government has listed the Income-tax (Amendment) Bill, 2026 and the Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises Development (Amendment) Bill, 2026, among the key economy-related legislations proposed for introduction during the Monsoon Session of Parliament beginning from Monday, according to the tentative legislative and financial business agenda circulated by the Ministry of Parliamentary Affairs.

The agenda also includes the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, which was introduced in the Lok Sabha on March 25 this year and has been listed for consideration and passing during the Monsoon session.

According to the official document, the Income-tax



(Amendment) Bill, 2026, which will replace an Ordinance, “seeks to deepen India’s sovereign debt market, attract stable global capital inflows, and enhance liquidity in view of the prevailing global macro-economic environment, marked by significant volatility arising from geopolitical uncertainties, sharp increases in crude oil prices, and disruptions in global supply chains.”

In simple terms, the Bill seeks to strengthen India’s gov-

ernment bond market, encourage stable foreign investment and improve the availability of funds in the financial system amid global economic uncertainty, rising crude oil prices and supply chain disruptions.

The legislative agenda also states that the Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises Development (Amendment) Bill, 2026 seeks “to align the Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises Development Act, 2006 with the changing MSME

‘Proposed law aims to make it easier for MSMEs to do business, improve the system for resolving delayed payment issues...’

landscape, to enhance the Ease of Doing Business and bring trust-based regulations in the MSME ecosystem.”

The document further says the Bill proposes “to strengthen the mechanism for addressing delayed payments and provide for enforcement of arbitral awards for the MSEs, and to introduce flexibility and create enabling provisions for States to decide the composition of the Micro and Small Enterprises Facilitation Council (MSEFC),

thereby forming more MSE-FCs.” The proposed law aims to make it easier for MSMEs to do business, improve the system for resolving delayed payment issues, ensure arbitration awards can be enforced, and give states greater flexibility to constitute more Facilitation Councils for resolving disputes involving micro and small enterprises.

Separately, the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, which is already pending before the Lok Sabha, has been included in the government’s list of business for consideration and passing during the session.

The Monsoon Session of Parliament is scheduled to begin on July 20 and continue until August 13, with a break for Independence Day celebrations before the Houses reconvene if required.

Govt reviews industrial corridor framework to speed up projects

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The government has launched a review of the institutional and implementation framework governing industrial corridors, industrial parks and integrated manufacturing ecosystems, seeking to identify bottlenecks and recommend reforms to accelerate project delivery and improve investor experience.

As part of the exercise, NITI Aayog will this week hold a stakeholder consultation to gather recommendations on policy, regulatory, institutional and implementation changes needed to strengthen India’s industrial competitiveness and support its goal of becoming a developed nation by 2047, sources said.

The review is being undertaken under the guidance of the High-Level Committee on Implementation of Viksit Bharat Goals (HLC-VB), chaired by NITI Aayog member Rajiv Gauba, which was constituted by the government to monitor key development programmes and infrastruc-



ture projects and recommend measures to speed up implementation.

The consultation will focus on five broad areas: project planning and land development, regulatory and institutional reforms, project execution and delivery, connectivity and logistics, and improving investor experience and future readiness.

Stakeholders have been asked to identify implementation bottlenecks, their underlying causes and practical reforms, while indicating whether the proposed changes require administrative action, policy or regulatory changes, legislative amendments or digital interventions.

They will be asked to flag

implementation delays and propose fixes including in master planning, approvals, land allotment, contracting, and last-mile logistics connectivity, and to specify whether recommended reforms would require administrative action, regulatory changes, legislative amendments or digital interventions.

Sources said the exercise aims to improve project delivery, reduce implementation timelines and enhance the competitiveness of India’s industrial infrastructure.

The objective of the consultation is to identify systemic policy, regulatory, institutional and implementation reforms that can improve the planning, development and operation of industrial corridors, industrial parks and other industrial infrastructure initiatives across the country.

Stakeholders may also indicate whether their recommendations require administrative action, policy/regulatory changes, legislative amendments or digital interventions, they added.

Pvt ports set to outgrow industry as container traffic surges, says report

NEW DELHI: India’s port sector is entering a differentiated growth phase, with container volumes emerging as the strongest driver while coal traffic declines and POL and iron ore post moderate gains.

According to a research report by Motilal Oswal Financial Services, “Container traffic is expected to remain a key growth driver for Indian ports, supported by favourable macroeconomic conditions, rising domestic consumption, and greater adoption of containerisation, with volumes projected to expand at a 7-9% CAGR over FY26-FY28,” the brokerage said.

The brokerage expects private players to gain disproportionately. “While the industry growth rate is expected to be

4-5% over the medium term, both APSEZ and JSWINFRA are set for sustained growth of 2-3x the industry, supported by continued organic and inorganic expansions and integrated logistics solutions,” the brokerage said.

Policy support is providing the tailwind. Under NMP 2.0, the government has identified 44 brownfield port infrastructure projects—including terminals, berths, and jetties—for monetisation through PPP models aiming to unlock INR 1.2 trillion during FY26-FY30.

The larger ambition comes from Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision 2047, which “aims to develop six mega ports with world-class infrastructure and boost India’s total port handling

capacity from 2,800 MTPA to 10,000 MTPA by 2047,” according to the brokerage.

FY26 data shows the divergence between major and non-major ports. India’s major ports delivered strong performance in FY26, with cargo volumes rising ~7% YoY to 915 MMT, driven by healthy growth in both overseas (+6.6% YoY) and coastal (+8% YoY) traffic. POL & crude led with 16% YoY growth, while coal and containers also posted robust gains. In contrast, “non-major ports reported modest growth, with cargo volumes increasing ~1.4% YoY to 753 MMT in FY26,” the report said.

Commodity mix is shifting. Coal traffic is likely to “post a compounding decline of 2-4%” as domestic produc-

tion and renewables rise, while “iron ore traffic is expected to recover at a 5-7% CAGR during FY26-FY28” on higher coastal movement. “POL traffic is projected to clock a moderate 2-4% CAGR over FY26-FY28, driven by stable fuel demand but moderated by improving fuel efficiency.”

India’s location adds to the opportunity. Motilal said, “Aided by 20,275km of national waterways across 24 states, the sector benefits from its strategic location in the Indian Ocean.

Motilal expects strong earnings growth for Adani Ports and JSW Infrastructure, saying India’s strategic location supports its maritime ambitions, though geopolitical risks, competition and policy uncertainty remain key challenges. AGENCIES

Panel on SEZ policy reforms to soon submit its report: Official

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 17-member committee to suggest larger reforms in the policy for special economic zones (SEZs) will soon submit its report to the commerce ministry, an official said.

The report, which will be submitted to Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agarwal, may include suggestions to revamp these zones to boost domestic manufacturing, exports and cut imports, the official said.

The committee has held meetings with different stakeholders on the issues pertaining to these zones.

The committee has focused on issues such as harmonisation of various prevalent export promotion schemes, including SEZs, export-oriented units (EoUs), MOOWR (Manufacturing and Other Operations in Warehouse), Advance Authorisation, EPCG (Export Promotion for Capital Goods), and Duty-Free

CLOSER LOOK

- » The report, which will be submitted to Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agarwal, may include suggestions to revamp these zones to boost domestic manufacturing, exports and cut imports
- » The committee has held meetings with different stakeholders on the issues pertaining to these zones
- » The total exports from these zones rose 7.37 per cent to USD 172.27 billion in 2024-25

Import Authorisation (DFIA). “The report will be submitted soon,” the official said.

The terms of reference of the committee included identification of oper-

ational, procedural, and regulatory challenges faced by SEZ developers and units; reviewing the fiscal impact of SEZs and related reforms on revenue, including foregone duties and taxes; and assessing the cost-benefit outcomes in terms of exports, investment and economic activity.

The committee will recommend short-term, medium-term and long-term policy, legal and procedural reforms, including possible amendments to the SEZ Act/Rules, and suggest an implementation roadmap with clear timelines.

The move is important as when the SEZ law was formulated in 2005, Indian trade policy was different, and now the situation has changed due to global developments.

The total exports from these zones rose 7.37 per cent to USD 172.27 billion in 2024-25. There are 276 operational SEZs, with 6,279 units, in the country.

India, Spain to fast-track UPI-Bizum interoperability talks

NEW DELHI: India and Spain have agreed to fast-track discussions on enabling interoperability between India’s Unified Payments Interface (UPI) and Spain’s Bizum digital payments platform, the Commerce Ministry said on Sunday. The two countries have also discussed ways to strengthen investment facilitation, improving mobility of professionals and promoting joint investments in Latin America, leveraging Spain’s strategic position as India’s gateway to Europe and Latin America. These issues came up for discussion during the recent visit of Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal to Spain.

“Both sides also agreed to advance technical discussions for interoperability between India’s UPI and Spain’s Bizum digital payments platform,” the ministry said.

The two sides have also identified significant opportunities in automobiles, pharmaceuticals, chemicals, textiles, renewable energy, tourism and infrastructure.

During his visit to Brussels, he raised the issue of the listing of Indian ship recycling yards.

He also proposed launching an India-EU dialogue on skills, education and talent mobility. The discussions covered negotiations on the proposed Investment Protection and Geographical Indications agreements, cooperation on the Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM), regulatory simplification, market access for agricultural products, duty derogation on Basmati rice and steel scrap. The minister also urged KONE and Nokia to significantly expand manufacturing, research and development, exports, and digital infrastructure. PTI

Show DND choice to users, not ‘frequently blocked’ label: TRAI on dedicated series row with Truecaller

NEW DELHI: TRAI has objections to Truecaller displaying a ‘frequently blocked’ badge within the dedicated number series, with a senior regulatory official saying that such tagging is “not advisable” as it tends to misguide and confuse telecom consumers, creating unwarranted suspicion about calls from 1600 and 140 categories that otherwise fall under the regulated framework.

Instead, the regulator believes that Truecaller should display a label informing users that they can “exercise their choice” to block unwanted

TRAI: ‘The solution lies in creating further awareness & outreach around the DND’

communication from the 140 series through TRAI’s official Do Not Disturb (DND) preference management app.

According to the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) official, the solution lies in creating further awareness and outreach around the DND, to educate people about the choices they have.

TRAI has mandated the use of 1600 series numbers for service and transaction calls by

regulated banking, financial services and insurance or BFSI entities, and government-to-citizen communications, while the 140 series numbers are for promotional calls by registered entities across sectors.

The senior TRAI official also cautioned call management apps and users that under no circumstances should the 1600 number be tagged as such, given that this series is used for service and transac-

tion calls by regulated entities of the BFSI sector (entities regulated by RBI, SEBI, IRDAI and PFRDA) to their existing customers and by government entities for government-to-citizen communication.

TRAI said tagging 140 and 1600 series calls as “spam” or “frequently blocked” could mislead consumers and undermine legitimate communications. It maintained that most spam originates from ordinary numbers, while the regulated series operates under strict registration and consumer-controlled DND safeguards. PTI

Eateries face CCPA action

NEW DELHI: The Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA) has initiated suo motu action against 41 restaurants for automatically levying service charges, calling it an unfair trade practice. Consumer Affairs Minister Pralhad Joshi said the restaurants have been directed to stop the practice. Chaayos was fined Rs 50,000 and ordered to refund affected customers and modify its billing system. The action follows consumer complaints and is backed by High Court’s ruling upholding the CCPA’s 2022 guidelines that service charges are voluntary. PTI

Reliance Retail to scale online business in FY27

Aims to double pre-tax earnings in 3 yrs

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Reliance Retail Ventures Ltd (RRVL) will ‘rapidly’ scale its online business, expand dark stores and strengthen omni-channel capabilities, as the retailer expects these investments to translate into higher margins and earnings growth, a top company official said.

Outlining a three-year roadmap, Reliance Retail CFO Dinesh Taluja said the company will invest in the infrastructure of JioMart and omni-channel reach across platforms, even as margins have come under pressure from rising technology and dark-store investments.

“We are looking at growing our online businesses pretty rapidly during this year. We will expand dark stores. We will grow our omni-channel platforms. We will grow JioMart,” Taluja said in the company’s earnings call.

Besides, it will also focus on improving the operational metrics around availability, speed, and reliability with a market-by-market focus on achieving positive unit economics.

“Each market, the unit economics, we need to have a clear path to positive unit economics. Accordingly, we are evaluating each and every market and focusing our investments in that manner,” Taluja said.

By FY28 and FY29, the company expects to convert scale into value by increasing repeat rates, basket size and customer lifetime value. In the next three years, Reliance Retail has an ambition of “2x Operating EBITDA”.

EBITDA refers to earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and amortisation.

According to him, the scale being built this year is expected to create value through improved margins and stronger cash generation over the next two years as customer acquisition, repeat purchases and basket sizes improve.

TAKEAWAYS

- » Reliance Retail CFO Dinesh Taluja said the company will invest in the infra of JioMart and omni-channel reach across platforms, even as margins have come under pressure...
- » ‘We are looking at growing our online businesses pretty rapidly during this year. We will expand dark stores. We will grow our omni-channel platforms. We will grow JioMart’: Taluja

The company also plans to improve profitability through a higher share of private labels, increased monetisation opportunities and greater market-place income.

“We will use all these levers to improve economics, which will start reflecting meaningfully in the numbers over the next two years,” he said.

Taluja said the current year will be focused on laying a strong foundation while pursuing disciplined growth, with emphasis on customer quality rather than merely chasing volumes. The company has set internal targets around metrics such as order density at dark stores, repeat purchase rates, fulfilment costs and contribution margins, and will calibrate investments based on performance.

“We will grow quite quickly, but we will also look at the quality of business, not just the volume,” he said.

Reliance Retail said its omni-channel strategy is boosting spending and digital orders, while AJIO Rush’s order volumes rose 136 per cent sequentially. The company expects improving returns, stronger cash generation and sustained growth through its hybrid JioMart network.

NEWLY UNSEALED FILINGS REVEAL DEFENCE STRATEGY

Inside the legal campaign that freed Gautam Adani from US prosecution

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 10-week defence campaign involving about 600 pages of legal submissions, presentations and expert testimony helped persuade the US Justice Department to drop bribery and securities fraud charges against billionaire Gautam Adani, according to newly unsealed court filings that detail how one of the year’s highest-profile corporate prosecutions was abandoned.

Robert J. Giuffra Jr, Adani’s lead lawyer and co-chair of Sullivan & Cromwell, in a July 14 filing said the effort, which ran from February 3 to April 17, included a 118-page submission to prosecutors, a 12-page supplemental filing and two slide presentations totalling 130 pages. A separate 151-page presentation was also submitted to the US Securities and Exchange Commission in March.

The filing provides the clearest public account yet of how federal prosecutors reversed course in one of the year’s most closely watched

corporate prosecutions.

The case began on November 20, 2024, when US prosecutors unsealed an indictment charging Gautam Adani, chairman of the Adani Group, his nephew and executive director at Adani Green Energy Ltd Sagar Adani, former Adani Green CEO Vneet Jaain and others with conspiring to pay more than USD 250 million in bribes to Indian government officials to secure solar energy supply contracts projected to generate more than USD 2 billion in after-tax profits over two decades.

Prosecutors had also alleged that the defendants misled investors about the alleged scheme, enabling the group to raise more than USD 3 billion through loans and bond issuances. The Adani Group has repeatedly denied the allegations, calling them baseless.

The case, unsealed during the final weeks of the Biden administration, remained largely dormant before the Department of Justice (DOJ) on May 18, 2026 moved to



“Filing offers the clearest public account yet of why prosecutors reversed course in one of the year’s most closely watched corporate prosecutions”

dismiss the indictment. Judge Nicolas Garaufis initially questioned the government’s brief explanation, calling it insufficient, and ordered prosecutors to publicly explain the basis for abandoning the case.

In a subsequent filing, Principal Associate Deputy Attorney General R. Trent McCotter

said the alleged conduct was overwhelmingly centred in India and cited jurisdictional and evidentiary challenges, the absence of identified investor losses and revised enforcement priorities.

The filing also said Indian authorities had examined the matter and argued the case had little realistic prospect of proceeding to trial.

In parallel civil proceedings, the Securities and Exchange Commission reached proposed settlements under which Gautam Adani agreed to pay a USD 6 million civil penalty and Sagar Adani USD 12 million, without admitting or denying the SEC’s allegations.

A Paper Avalanche

According to the declaration, filed in response to a pointed order from US District Judge Nicholas Garaufis, S&C’s team – engaged in August 2025, months after the indictment was unsealed – spent “many thousands of hours” dissecting the government’s theories before producing what Giuffra describes as a comprehen-

sive rebuttal delivered in stages between February and April 2026.

The submissions included a 118-page letter accompanied by a nine-page cover memo, a 12-page supplemental brief, and two slide presentations – 95 pages in February and 35 pages in April – laying out what the firm characterized as fatal flaws in the case: an improper extra-territorial reach of US securities law, statements the government treated as actionable that Second Circuit precedent would not support, and bribery allegations Giuffra called “implausible, internally inconsistent, and highly dependent on potential testimony that would lack credibility.”

The filing said four experts submitted nearly 200 pages of reports, while the defence delivered around 600 pages of legal arguments in 10 weeks.

It also revealed prosecutors rejected a proposed resolution linked to Adani’s planned USD 10 billion US investment, insisting it would not influence the criminal case.

GOVT, VCS TO JOINTLY FUND ADVANCED CHIP DESIGN: IT SECY

‘Semicon 2.0’: Equity norms likely to drive large investments for Indian cos

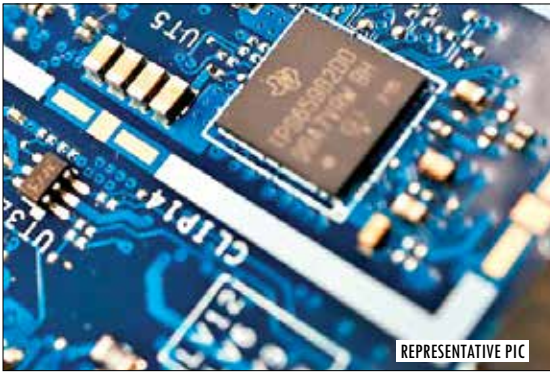
NEW DELHI: Provisions under Semicon 2.0 to provide incentives to Indian chip-making firms against equity are expected to drive large-scale investment required for the development of advanced chips for technology such as artificial intelligence, a senior government official has said.

Under Semicon 2.0, which has a budget of Rs 1.27 lakh crore, the central government has prioritised chip design by Indian companies.

In an interview, Ministry of Electronics and IT Secretary S Krishnan said advance chip design may need thousands of crores of investments.

“We intend to provide more funding. Otherwise, under design-linked incentive scheme, you get only about Rs 15 crore. Now, to design high-end chips you need Rs 1,000 crore or more.

“At the same time, the government can’t give everything.



This is why you have this combination saying that you get investment from a venture capitalist or somebody who believes that you will be able to bring out this chip, and we will co-invest,” he said.

The government on July 15 approved Rs 1.27 lakh crore (around USD 14 billion) Semicon 2.0 programme to accelerate semiconductor design and manufacturing capabilities. The initiative will be in effect

for six years starting FY27.

The government has not announced a cap for investment in advance chip design by Indian firms. It will provide incentive to Indian chip companies in the form of grant and equity or link it to royalty base payment.

“The idea of co-investment is two-fold. One, that we increase the overall funding, which is available. Two, the government doesn’t do the

HIGHLIGHTS

» Under Semicon 2.0, which has a budget of Rs 1.27 lakh crore, the central government has prioritised chip design by Indian companies

» In an interview, Ministry of Electronics and IT Secretary S Krishnan said advance chip design may need thousands of crores of investments

ing our own advance chips. Whether we will be able to manufacture it in the country, we don’t know. I don’t think we will get there yet. We are not looking at that market yet,” Krishnan said.

The manufacturing of advance chips might take time but the design of these will happen in the coming years, Krishnan said.

Currently, advance chips are considered semiconductor that contain 7 nano meter and smaller nodes.

India’s first chip manufacturing unit will start with production old technology node of 28 nanometer, which is generally used for power electronics.

The government approved Semicon 2.0 with an aim to develop IPs, designs of chips and systems.

The work under Semicon 2.0 is expected to place India as a key semiconductor chip-design IP country. **PTI**

Mcap of 5 of top-10 most valued firms jumps Rs 1.54L crore

NEW DELHI: The combined market valuation of five of the top-10 most valued firms jumped Rs 1.54 lakh crore last week, with IT major TCS emerging as the biggest winner, in line with a positive trend in equities.

Last week, the BSE benchmark Sensex climbed 582.06 points, or 0.75 per cent, and the NSE Nifty went up by 127.4 points, or 0.52 per cent.

“Indian equity markets ended the week on a firm footing, extending their recovery despite heightened geopolitical tensions, elevated crude oil prices, and persistent uncertainty surrounding the global interest-rate outlook.

“Sentiment remained supported by encouraging Q1 FY27 earnings from the IT sector as TCS closed with nearly 10 per cent of weekly gains, renewed buying interest in financial stocks, and resilience in domestic economic fundamentals,” Ajit Mishra – SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.

While Reliance Industries, ICICI Bank, State Bank of India, Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) and Bajaj Finance emerged as the gainers, HDFC Bank, Bharti Airtel, Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC), Larsen & Toubro and Hindustan Unilever faced erosion from their valuation.

TCS added Rs 72,072.3 crore, taking its market valuation to Rs 8,20,672.70 crore.

The country’s largest IT services company reported a 4.61 per cent increase in its June-quarter net profit to Rs 13,349 crore, and guided towards an improvement in demand, impacted by the West Asia crisis, returning in the ongoing quarter.

ICICI Bank’s valuation surged Rs 29,062.06 crore to Rs 10,34,441.77 crore and that of Reliance Industries jumped Rs 23,884.93 crore to Rs 17,95,091.26 crore.

The valuation of Bajaj Finance climbed Rs 21,946.5 crore to Rs 6,57,274.28 crore and that of State Bank of India went up by Rs 7,338.34 crore to Rs 9,63,768.78 crore.

However, the market capitalisation (mcap) of Larsen & Toubro eroded by Rs 18,097.72 crore to Rs 5,24,840.68 crore.

The valuation of LIC declined by Rs 12,080.75 crore to Rs 5,48,124.30 crore.

Bharti Airtel’s mcap tumbled Rs 7,706.45 crore to Rs 11,91,067.77 crore and that of HDFC Bank edged lower by Rs 7,084.61 crore to Rs 12,62,369.81 crore.

The mcap of Hindustan Unilever dipped Rs 1,221.79 crore to Rs 5,03,775.86 crore.

Reliance Industries remained the most valued firm followed by HDFC Bank, Bharti Airtel, ICICI Bank, State Bank of India, TCS, Bajaj Finance, LIC, Larsen & Toubro and Hindustan Unilever. **AGENCIES**

‘Panel on SEZ policy reforms to submit its report soon’

NEW DELHI: A 17-member committee to suggest larger reforms in the policy for special economic zones will soon submit its report to the Commerce ministry, an official said.

The report, which will be submitted to Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agarwal, may include suggestions to revamp these zones to boost domestic manufacturing, exports and cut imports.

The panel has held meetings with different stakeholders on the issues pertaining to these zones. It has focused on issues such as harmonisation of various prevalent export promotion schemes, including SEZs, export-oriented units, Manufacturing and Other Operations in Warehouse, Advance Authorisation, EPCG, and Duty-Free Import Authorisation (DFIA). **MPOST**

ASEAN, Africa lead India’s export growth in first 2 months of FY27

NEW DELHI: Asean and African regions emerged as the biggest contributors to India’s export growth during the first two months of the current fiscal, according to the commerce ministry data.

During April-May 2026-27, exports rose 16.09 per cent year-on-year to USD 88.91 billion.

The data showed that the country’s exports to Asean (Association of South East Asian nations) jumped 66.9 per cent to USD 10.5 billion from USD 6.3 billion a year ago, while shipments to Africa surged 53.1 per cent to USD 9.6 billion from USD 6.3 billion.

Together, these two regions have added over USD 7.6 billion in exports compared with the corresponding period of the previous fiscal, accounting for a significant share of India’s overall export expansion.

Further, despite modest growth, NAFTA (US, Canada and Mexico) remained India’s



largest export destination with shipments rising 2.6 per cent to USD 19.3 billion from USD 18.8 billion, while exports to Europe increased 4 per cent to USD 17 billion from USD 16.4 billion.

Exports to North East Asia also recorded robust growth of 30.7 per cent to USD 8.3 billion, while South Asia registered a 40.2 per cent rise to USD 6.1 billion.

Similarly, shipments to Latin America and the Caribbean (LAC) grew 12.5 per cent to USD 3 billion, Oceania (Australia and New Zealand) recorded a 29 per cent increase to USD 2.1 billion, and exports to the CIS (commonwealth of independent states) countries rose 7.7 per cent to USD 1.1 billion.

CIS nations include Russia, Armenia, Belarus, and Kazakhstan.

The data indicated that regions outside north America and Europe now account for more than half of India’s exports, underscoring the country’s strategy of diversifying export destinations amid global economic uncertainties.

India’s total exports of goods and services during April-May FY27 were estimated at USD 162.69 billion, up 14.66 per cent over the year-ago period. **MPOST**

PSPCL sets 2-day deadline for disposal of lawyers’ tariff change requests

PATIALA: Punjab State Power Corporation Limited (PSPCL) has directed all Sub-Division Offices to process applications for conversion of electricity connections in eligible lawyers’ chambers from Commercial Tariff to Domestic Supply (DS) Tariff within two days of receipt.

The directive was issued by PSPCL Chairman-cum-Managing Director Basant Garg after complaints of delays in implementing the Punjab government’s notification extending the DS Tariff benefit to advocates’ chambers in court complexes.

The decision followed representations made by lawyers to Chief Minister Bhagwant Singh Mann seeking relief from commercial electricity charges.

The benefit is available only to chambers of advocates registered with the Punjab and Haryana Bar Council, used only for legal practice. **MPOST**

Deloitte projects 6.5–6.8% GDP expansion in FY27, growth to strengthen in 2nd half

‘Growth likely to remain moderate in first half of FY2026–27’

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Deloitte India on Sunday projected India’s economy to grow at 6.5–6.8 per cent in the current fiscal, with growth expected to strengthen in the second half of the year supported by festive demand, monetary easing, and a gradual stabilisation in global conditions.

In its latest edition of Economic Outlook report, Deloitte said India entered 2026 in a Goldilocks phase, with macroeconomic fundamentals appearing unusually well balanced, but geopolitical developments altered the global landscape with tensions in the Middle East disrupting critical shipping routes, triggering volatility in commodity prices and weakening investor sentiment.

This resulted in a wider trade deficit, sustained capital outflows, and a sharp depreciation of the rupee against the US dollar within a matter of weeks.

Against this backdrop, the RBI had last month lowered India’s GDP growth estimates



for current fiscal to 6.6 per cent, from 6.9 per cent estimated earlier. GDP grew 7.7 per cent in the previous (2025–26) fiscal.

Deloitte India Economist, Rumki Majumdar said the global environment has become considerably more uncertain. “While recent geopolitical developments and the RBI’s policy measures may help cushion some of these risks, weather-related uncertainties, particularly the impact of El Nino on agricultural output and food prices, remain an important downside risk,” she said.

“Deloitte expects India’s economy to grow between 6.5 per cent and 6.8 per cent in

FY2026–27. Growth is likely to remain moderate in the first half before strengthening in the second half, supported by festive demand, monetary easing, and a gradual stabilisation in global conditions,” Majumdar said.

Despite near-term headwinds, Deloitte remains optimistic about India’s medium-term growth prospects. One of the strongest reasons is India’s accelerated pursuit of Free Trade Agreements (FTAs) with large and strategically important markets, the report said.

“As FTAs deepen, India’s priority must be to convert market access into lasting com-

petitiveness. Greater import resilience should not translate into permanent import dependence. Trade policy must therefore be complemented by industrial policy, world-class infrastructure, stronger domestic supplier ecosystems, easier compliance, and continued investment in innovation and skills to raise domestic value addition over time,” Majumdar said.

Inflation remains one of the key risks to the growth outlook as higher prices of crude oil, fertilisers, essential minerals, and edible oils, together with a weaker rupee, are gradually feeding into domestic prices, the report said.

CLOSER LOOK

» Deloitte said India entered 2026 in a Goldilocks phase, with macroeconomic fundamentals appearing unusually well balanced, but geopolitical developments altered the global landscape

» Despite near-term headwinds, Deloitte remains optimistic about India’s medium-term growth prospects

India, EU reaffirm commitment to ‘early’ signing of trade pact

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Union Commerce and Industry minister Piyush Goyal concluded a five-day visit to Spain, Belgium, Finland and Estonia with India and the European Union reaffirming their commitment to the early signing and implementation of the proposed Free Trade Agreement (FTA), according to a Ministry of Commerce and Industry release issued on Sunday.

The ministry said the visit, held from July 13 to 18, was aimed at deepening India’s economic partnership with Europe, expanding investment ties and strengthening technology cooperation.

“Both sides reaffirmed their commitment to work towards the early signing and implementation of the India-EU FTA,” the ministry said, referring to Goyal’s meetings in Brussels with European Council President Antonio Costa, European Commissioner for Trade Maros Sefcovic and other senior EU leaders.

The release said the discussions also covered negotiations on the Investment Protection Agreement and the Geographical Indications Agreement, cooperation on the Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM), regulatory simplification, market access for agricultural products, and duty derogation for Basmati rice and steel scrap.

During the Brussels visit, Goyal co-chaired the third India-EU Trade and Technology Council (TTC) Ministerial Meeting and welcomed the adoption of the 2026–27 TTC Action Plan. The ministry said India also proposed launching an India-EU dialogue on skills, education and talent mobility and raised the issue of listing Indian ship recycling yards.

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In Spain, Goyal proposed

an annual India-Spain Joint Commission meeting with business participation and unveiled a “10x10x10” vision to increase bilateral trade, investment and tourism tenfold over the next decade.

The two sides also agreed to advance technical discussions on interoperability between India’s Unified Payments Interface (UPI) and Spain’s Bizum digital payments platform while identifying opportunities in automobiles, pharmaceuticals, renewable energy, tourism and infrastructure.

In Finland, Goyal invited companies to expand manufacturing, research and development, exports and digital infrastructure investments in India. The ministry said, “India’s scale and talent, combined with Finland’s technological capabilities, offer significant opportunities for co-development and co-manufacturing.”

The minister concluded the visit in Estonia, where both sides explored cooperation in digital governance, fintech, UPI integration, cybersecurity and emerging technologies.

ADDITIONAL ROLE

Rahul Himalian takes charge as IRCTC CMD

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Consequent upon the resignation of Sanjay Kumar Jain as Chairman & Managing Director (CMD), Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation Ltd. (IRCTC), the Ministry of Railways has entrusted the additional charge of the post of CMD, IRCTC to Rahul Himalian, Director (Tourism & Marketing), IRCTC.

A senior and distinguished officer of the Indian Railway Traffic Service (IRTS) from the 1999 examination batch, Rahul Himalian has over 26 years of rich and diverse experience in the Indian Railways and IRCTC.

He has been serving as a Whole-Time Functional Director on the Board of IRCTC, a Schedule ‘A’ Navratna Central Public Sector Enterprise under the Ministry of Railways, since



Rahul Himalian

February 16, 2024.

In his capacity as Director (Tourism & Marketing), he has been providing leadership to key departments including Tourism, Information Technology, Human Resource Development, Infrastructure, Administration and Rajbhasha.

With the assumption of the additional charge of CMD, Rahul Himalian will lead the overall operations and strategic direction of IRCTC while continuing to discharge his responsibilities as Director (Tourism & Marketing).

Gold and silver brace for another ‘tough week’ amid oil surge

On the Multi Commodity Exchange (MCX), gold futures for August delivery declined Rs 2,572, or nearly 2 per cent, closing at Rs 1.4 lakh per 10 grams.

Silver for the September contract slumped Rs 6,261, or 2.8 per cent, to Rs 2.16 lakh per kilogram on the MCX.

“Gold extended its corrective phase last week as a stronger US dollar, firm crude oil prices, and expectations of prolonged higher interest rates continued to weigh on bullion,” said Jateen Trivedi, VP Research Analyst - Commodity

and Currency, LKP Securities.

He said every rebound in gold attracted fresh selling pressure, suggesting traders preferred booking gains rather than building fresh long positions. The rupee’s mild correction offered little support as the stronger dollar continued to dominate sentiment.

In global markets, Comex gold futures slipped USD 95, or 2.3 per cent, to close at USD 4,018.8 per ounce during the past week, while silver plunged nearly USD 4, or 6.4 per cent, to USD 56.32 per ounce in New

York. Mer said gold and silver recovered on Friday but still ended the week in the red territory as crude oil prices surged more than 14 per cent on fears of supply disruptions, while rising Treasury yields further dented bullion’s appeal.

Praveen Singh, Head of Commodities at Mirae Asset ShareKhan, said hawkish comments from Federal Reserve Chair Kevin Warsh’s have offset the impact of softer US inflation data, reinforcing expectations of tighter monetary policy. **AGENCIES**

GLOBAL TRADE PRESSURES

Aluminium industry seeks FinMin support

NEW DELHI: The Aluminium Association of India has sought the finance ministry’s support, citing shrinking export markets due to high US tariffs, rising protectionism in Mexico, Indonesia’s capacity expansion, Russian dumping, and a surge in low-quality scrap and aluminium imports from Gulf and ASEAN countries.

In a representation to the Central Board of Indirect Taxes (CBIC), the association said since the world is using and promoting imports of only high-quality scrap, it is the need of the hour for India to establish similar quality standards.

It said that as major economies are protecting their domestic aluminium industries through higher import duties and other trade measures to attract investments, expand capacities and reduce import dependence, India should also strengthen safeguards.

It urged the government to continue the existing duty structure on aluminium products and consider higher basic customs duty and other trade measures to curb the surge in

imports of poor quality scrap, citing examples of countries such as Mexico, the US and Canada, where duties range between 15 per cent and 50 per cent. The association has requested to ensure that the final BIS standard titled ‘Aluminium & Aluminium Alloy Scrap - Requirements & Conditions of Delivery’ is notified without changes, saying it has already been approved by bodies such as NITI Aayog, and BIS.

It said that this will ensure that India does not become a dumping ground for unchecked quality of hazardous global aluminium scrap.

Once notified, it would classify aluminium scrap into different grades based on aluminium content, ranging from above 95 per cent to below 60 per cent, it said.

The association has urged the government to maintain the existing import duty on aluminium scrap until the pending BIS quality standard is notified and grade-wise HSN (harmonised nomenclature) codes are introduced. **AGENCIES**

‘RECOGNITION BELONGS TO ALL OF US’

Mammootty, Yami Gautam and Kartik Aaryan expressed their gratitude for winning top honours at the 72nd National Film Awards



Mammootty and Aaryan shared the ‘Best Actor’ award for ‘Bramayugam’ and ‘Chandu Champion’

Mammootty, Yami Gautam and Kartik Aaryan expressed their gratitude for winning top honours at the 72nd National Film Awards announced on Saturday.

Veteran Malayalam actor Mammootty and Aaryan shared the ‘Best Actor’ award for ‘Bramayugam’ and ‘Chandu Champion’, respectively. Mammootty, who plays a menacing role in the period folk horror film, posted on ‘X’, “Thanks Team Bramayugam and Rahul Sadasivan (writer-director) for entrusting me with ‘Kodumon Potty’ (his character in the film). The 74-year-old actor, who won his fourth National Film Award, also congratulated the other winners, saying, “Truly well deserved!”

Veteran actor-politician Kamal Haasan congratulated the Malayalam star and his friend on winning yet another National Award. “You once promised me you would overtake me in the number of National Awards. As always, you are a man of your word! Here’s to many more accolades, my friend,” Haasan said.

Haasan’s Telugu sci-fi movie, ‘Kalki 2898 AD’, won the ‘Best Popular Film Providing Whole-some Entertainment’ award at the nationals. “Congratulations as well to all the winners of the 72nd National Film Awards. Special congratulations to @Nagashwin7 @vyjayanthifilms and the entire #Kalki2898AD family. Indian cinema is richer because of your excellence,” Haasan said.

Production banner ‘Vyjayanthi Films’ also shared a note of gratitude on social media for the recognition of ‘Kalki 2898 AD’, calling it a ‘celebration’ of every artiste and technician associated with the film. “The next chapter carries not just our vision, but your belief. We promise to make the wait for #Kalki2 worth it,” the post said.

Actor-filmmaker Dhanush expressed his gratitude after winning two National Awards - for his directorial venture ‘Raayan’ and for his perfor-



mance in ‘Captain Miller’. “This recognition for ‘Captain Miller’ is especially close to my heart because I have always believed it to be my finest performance to date,” Dhanush said in a note, adding that receiving a ‘Special Mention’ for a performance he holds so dearly made the honour even more meaningful.

Reacting to the honour, Aaryan said he is ‘still processing’ his first National Award for ‘Chandu Champion’, in which he played India’s first Paralympic gold medalist, Murlikant Petkar. The film is directed by Kabir Khan and produced by Sajid Nadiadwala. “Some moments are simply bigger than words and this is one of them. A dream I’ve carried for years has finally come true. Forever humbled, forever grateful,” the actor said.

Nadiadwala congratulated Aaryan and said it is a moment of ‘pure joy and immense pride’ for the entire team of ‘Chandu Champion’.

Yami Gautam expressed gratitude for winning her first National Award for her performance as an intelligence officer in

the political drama ‘Article 370’. “Every journey has a moment that reminds you why you never gave up. Today is that moment for me. I will cherish it for the rest of my life,” she wrote on ‘Instagram’.

Based on the 2019 revocation of Article 370 of the Constitution that granted special status to the erstwhile state of Jammu and Kashmir, the movie also won ‘Best Feature Film’ for Aditya Suhas Jambhale and ‘Best Music Direction’ for Shashwat Sachdev.

Calling the honour the culmination of perseverance and dedication to her craft, Gautam, who recently completed 14 years in Hindi cinema, said, “It is a dream I’ve carried in my heart for years and today, I receive it with immense gratitude and humility.”

She added that it is a deeply emotional moment as the film is a home production driven by a shared commitment to tell an honest story. Gautam also said the award is not the ‘end of a dream; it is the beginning of a greater responsibility’. “Keep growing, to keep taking risks and to keep telling stories that matter. Dreams do come true, but only when passion refuses to give up. This one’s for every dreamer who is still waiting for their moment. Never stop believing,” she said.

Gautam’s filmmaker husband Aditya Dhar, who backed the movie, described the recognition as ‘deeply humbling’ and credited the film’s success to its cast, crew and audiences. “Your love gave this film a life far beyond the screen,” he said.

Director Suhas Jambhale said, “This is my third National Award and the feeling of receiving this honour is just as overwhelming and deeply humbling.” Jambhale had won the National Award for his Marathi short film ‘Khar-

72nd NATIONAL FILM AWARDS 2026	
FEATURE FILM AWARDS	
★ Best Feature Film: Article 370	★ Best Film Promoting Social Values: Captain Miller
★ Best Hindi Film: Srikanth	★ Best Children's Film: 35 Chinna Katha Kaadu
★ Best Debut Director: Randeep Hooda - Swatantrya Veer Savarkar	★ Best Tamil Film: Raayan
★ Best Popular Film: Kalki 2898 AD	
PERFORMANCE AWARDS	
★ Best Actor: Kartik Aaryan (Chandu Champion) & Mammootty (Bramayugam)	
★ Best Actress: Yami Gautam (Article 370)	
★ Best Supporting Actress: Sachana Namidass (Maharaja) & Rapshee Varkady (Mithya)	
★ Best Female Playback Singer: Vaikom Vijayalakshmi	
DIRECTION & TECHNICAL	
★ Best Director: Rajkumar Periasamy (Amaran)	
★ Best Cinematography: Shehnad Jalal (Bramayugam)	
★ Best Screenplay: Bandreddi Sukumar (Pushpa: The Rule - Part 2)	
★ Best Editing: K. Kalaiyavan (Amaran)	
★ Best Background Score: GV Prakash Kumar (Amaran)	

vas’ (2018) and for his debut short film ‘Aaba Aiktaay Naa?’ (2016). Jyoti Deshpande, President of ‘Jio Studios’, termed the film’s triple honours an ‘incredibly emotional moment’.

Randeep Hooda, who won the ‘Best Debut Director’ award for ‘Swatantrya Veer Savarkar’, expressed his gratitude to his team for believing in him and standing by him through the highs and lows. “This recognition belongs to all of us, and I hope it inspires more people, especially the younger generation, to discover and reflect on Veer Savarkar’s legacy,” the actor said. Hooda, who also co-wrote the film and starred in the titular role, described it as the most demanding project of his career.

Sanjay Mishra was honoured with the ‘Best Supporting Actor’ award for his performance in ‘Bhakshak’. The ‘Netflix’ film, which starred Bhumi Pednekar in the lead role, uncovers the sexual abuse of young children at a shelter home. “Receiving the National Award is a huge honour for me. This really touched my heart,” said the veteran actor, who played a small-town cameraman working for a local news channel in ‘Bhakshak’.

Pednekar took to ‘Instagram’ to congratulate Mishra on winning the award. “My dearest @imsanjaymishra, you are a force of nature and it’s always an honour to work with you. Hearts happy,” she wrote.

In the feature film category, the Rajkumar Rao-starrer ‘Srikanth: Aa Raha Hai Sabki Aankhein Kholne’ won the Best Film award. Directed by Tushar Hiranandani and produced by Bhushan Kumar, Krishan Kumar and Nidhi Parmar Hiranandani, the film is a biopic of Srikanth Bolla (Rao), a visually impaired industrialist.

Hiranandani said the award is a tribute to Bolla’s life and the collective effort of the cast and crew. “Making ‘Srikanth’ has been one of the most fulfilling journeys of my career. This award is a tribute to Srikanth Bolla’s inspiring life and to every member of the cast and crew who poured their hearts into telling this story,” he said. Bhushan Kumar said the recognition is an honour for the entire team and credited Srikanth Bolla’s story for inspiring audiences.

Announced by the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, the awards recognised and celebrated achievements in Indian cinema in 2024.

THE BIG BANG THEORY

Jim reveals hidden toll of starring in it

Jim Parsons is best known for playing the beloved geeky physicist Sheldon Cooper in Chuck Lorre and Bill Prady’s popular sitcom ‘The Big Bang Theory’. Hailed as the longest-running multi-camera sitcom ever, the series consisted of 279 episodes, spread across 12 seasons and 12 years. It’s no surprise then that in hindsight, Parsons admitted he was ‘miserable’ and ‘stressed’ throughout the filming.



“I felt that there were so many plates I was supposed to be keeping in the air and that the success and the good things of life that were happening were only due to this overworking... discipline and whatever, maybe to a degree that was true.” AGENCIES

‘Finally our stars aligned!’

Actress Jennifer Winget tied the knot with businessman William Ishmael

Actress Jennifer Winget tied the knot with businessman William Ishmael. The actress, known for projects such as ‘Beyhadh’ and ‘Saraswathichandra’, shared the news with a video post on her ‘Instagram’ handle on Saturday, which featured a series of pictures. The slide in the video read, “Ladies and Gentlemen, will you stand? Officially introducing you to my husband, Will.”

It was followed by another slide which featured a picture of the rings and had ‘Just married’ written over it.

Winget wore a white off-shoulder corset dress and Ishmael opted for a blue suit with a white waistcoat. “And finally our stars aligned! @williamishmael,” read the caption.

The actress was previously married to Karan Singh Grover.



The duo tied the knot in 2012 but announced their divorce in 2014.

She last featured on screen in 2024 in ‘Raisinghani vs Raisinghani’. The series featured her alongside Karan Wahi and Reem Shaikh. It was created by Aniruddha Rajderkar and Bhavna Sresth.

‘Playing Hanuman in Ramayana was not easy’



Sunny Deol revealed that playing Hanuman in Nitesh Tiwari’s ‘Ramayana’ comes with a huge sense of responsibility. Speaking at a promotional event for the film at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi on July 18, the actor shared that he has only completed a small part of his work so far, with a long road still ahead. The Delhi

event marked an important moment in promoting the two-part epic. Shot for IMAX, the film’s first chapter is set to release in 2026, with the concluding part arriving in 2027.

The actor told everyone that he had just started working on ‘Ramayana’ and that there was still a lot to do before he could really understand the role. “To tell

you the truth, I have done only a little work on the film so far. I still have a long way to go,” he said.

For Sunny, the film’s huge scale is just one part of the challenge. ‘Ramayana’ means a lot to people in India, which makes playing one of its most loved characters a bigger responsibility than a normal film role.

RAKUL PREET SINGH CALLS ‘RAMAYANA’ BIGGER THAN CINEMA

She’ll be seen portraying Surpanakha, the powerful and fierce sister of demon king Ravana

Rakul Preet Singh expressed her excitement and pride about being part of the much-anticipated epic ‘Ramayana’. She called the project a journey that goes beyond cinema. In her recent post on ‘Instagram’, the actress shared that being associated with a story rooted in India’s history, heritage and culture is an honour and a truly unforgettable experience.

Rakul shared glimpses from the grand trailer launch event of ‘Ramayana’ and opened up about being a part of the epic project. Sharing pictures from the special occasion, the ‘Runway 34’ actress wrote, “An honour to be a part of something that feels larger than life, larger than cinema, our history, our heritage, our ‘Ramayana’. We represent Bharat to the world, a feeling that’s truly beyond words. Can’t wait for you all to step into this world with us.”

Rakul Preet Singh will be seen portraying Surpanakha, the powerful and fierce sister of demon king Ravana, in Nitesh Tiwari’s upcoming two-part epic ‘Ramayana’. The ambitious adaptation features Ranbir Kapoor as Lord Rama, Sai



Pallavi as Sita and Yash as Ravana in pivotal roles.

The film is planned for a two-part release, with the first instalment arriving during Diwali 2026, followed by the second during Diwali 2027.

The grand trailer launch of ‘Ramayana’ took place in Delhi on July 18. The star-studded event was attended by Ranbir Kapoor, Sai Pallavi, Ravi Dubey, director Nitesh Tiwari, producer Namit Malhotra, Kunal Kapoor, Rakul Preet Singh, Vivek Oberoi, Arun Govil, Ajinkya Deo, Shobhna, sitar maestro Rishabh Rikhi, Ram Sharma, Swami Ramdev, Ashwiny Iyer Tiwari, Karan Johar, Apoorva Mehta and others.



‘We represent Bharat to the world, a feeling that’s truly beyond words,’ she says